

Aeschylus
THE EUMENIDES
[THE KINDLY ONES]

Translated by
Ian Johnston
Vancouver Island University
Nanaimo, BC
Canada

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Note that in the following text the line numbers in square brackets refer to the Greek text, and the line numbers without brackets refer to the text of the translation.

In this translation, possessives of names ending in -s are usually indicated in the common way (that is, by adding -'s (e.g. *Zeus* and *Zeus's*). This convention adds a syllable to the spoken word (the sound -iz). Sometimes, for metrical reasons, this English text indicates such possession in an alternate manner, with a simple apostrophe. This form of the possessive does not add an extra syllable to the spoken name (e.g., *Orestes* and *Orestes'* are both three-syllable words).

The *Eumenides* is the third play in the series of three plays which make up the *Oresteia*.

EUMENIDES

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

PRIESTESS: prophetic priestess (the Pythia) of Apollo at Delphi.

APOLLO: divine son of Zeus, god of prophecy.

ORESTES: son of Agamemnon and Clytaemnestra, brother of Electra.

CLYTAEMNESTRA: mother of Orestes, appearing as a ghost after her murder.

CHORUS: Furies, goddesses of blood revenge.

ATHENA: divine daughter of Zeus.

ATHENIAN CITIZENS.

[Scene: The play opens just in front of the temple of Apollo at Delphi. Enter the Pythia, the Priestess of Apollo.]

PRIESTESS

In my prayer, I hold Earth in highest honour,
as the first of prophets among all gods.
Then, after her came Themis. That goddess,
so the legend goes, followed her mother
at this seat of prophecy. Third in line,
another Titan, Phoebe, child of Earth,
was then assigned to occupy this throne.
There was no force—Themis approved the change.
Phoebe then gave it as a birthday gift
to the god who takes his name from her, 10
Phoebus Apollo. He left the island Delos,
moving from his lake and ridge to Pallas, [10]
to those shores where ships sail in to trade.
Then he came to live on Mount Parnassus.
A reverential escort came with him—
children of the fire god, Hephaestus,
highway builders who tame the wilderness
and civilize the land. As he marched here,
people came out in droves to worship him,
including their king and helmsman, Delphus. 20
Then Zeus inspired in him prophetic skills,
and set him on this throne as fourth in line.
Here Apollo speaks for Zeus, his father.
My prayers begin with preludes to these gods. [20]
My words also give special prominence
to the goddess who stands outside the shrine,
Pallas Athena. I revere those nymphs
inhabiting Corycia's rocky caves,
where flocks of birds delight to congregate,

where holy spirits roam. I don't forget 30
 how Dionysus, ruler of this land,
 divine commander of those Bacchic women,
 ripped Pentheus apart, as if he were
 a cornered rabbit. I also call upon
 the streams of Pleistus and Poseidon's power,
 and Zeus most high, who fulfills all things.
 I'll take my seat now on the prophet's throne.
 May I be fortunate, above the rest, [30]
 to see far more than previous attempts.
 If any Greeks are in attendance here, 40
 let them draw lots and enter, each in turn,
 as is our custom. I will prophesy,
 following directions from the god.

[The Priestess enters the temple, only to return immediately, very agitated. She collapses onto her hands and knees.]

It's horrible!
 Too horrible to say . . . awful to see.
 It drives me back . . . out of Apollo's shrine.
 My strength is gone . . . I can't stand up.
 I have to crawl on hands and knees—my legs
 just buckle under me . . . An old woman
 overcome with fear is nothing, a child.
 No more . . .

[The Priestess gathers herself together and stands with great difficulty, holding onto the temple doors for support.]

As I was entering the inner shrine— 50
 the part covered up with wreaths—I saw him, [40]
 right on the central navel stone, a man
 the gods despise, sitting there, in the seat
 reserved for suppliants, hands dripping blood.
 He'd drawn his sword, but held an olive branch.
 It had a tuft of wool on top, a mark
 of reverence—it was large and white.
 I saw all that distinctly. But then I saw
 in front of him something astonishing,
 on the benches groups of women sleeping— 60
 well, they weren't exactly women,
 I'd say more like Gorgons—then again,
 not much like Gorgons either. Years ago,

I once saw a picture of some monsters
 snatching a feast away from Phineas. [50]
 But the ones inside here have no wings—
 I checked. They're black and totally repulsive,
 with loud rasping snorts that terrify me.
 Disgusting pus comes oozing from their eyes.
 As for their clothing—quite inappropriate 70
 to wear before the statues of the gods,
 or even in men's homes. I've never seen
 a tribe which could produce this company,
 a country which would admit with pride
 that it had raised them without paying a price,
 without regretting all the pain they cost.
 Where does this end? That is Apollo's work. [60]
 Let that be his concern. His force is strong—
 what he reveals has healing power.
 He reads the omens and can purify 80
 the home, his own and other men's.

[The scene changes to reveal the inside of the temple, with Orestes clutching the central stone (the navel stone) and the Furies asleep in front of him. Apollo enters from the back of the temple (the inner shrine). Apollo moves to stand near Orestes.]

APOLLO

I'll not leave you—no, I'll stand beside you,
 your protector till the end. Close at hand
 or far away, I'll show no gentleness
 towards your enemies. Right now you see
 these frenzied creatures overcome with sleep,
 just lying there, these loathsome maidens,
 ancient children, hags. No god or man [70]
 or animal has intercourse with them.
 They're born for evil. That's why they live 90
 within the blackest gloom of Tartarus,
 under the earth. Olympian gods and men
 despise them. But you should still keep going.
 Do not give up. They'll chase you everywhere,
 as you move along well-traveled ground,
 across wide continents, beyond the seas,
 through cities with the ocean all around.
 Don't grow weary brooding on your pain.
 And then, once you reach Athena's city,
 sit down, and wrap your arms around her, 100 [80]
 embrace her image. With people there

to judge your cause and with the force of speech,
 the spell-binding power in words, we'll find
 a way to free you from misfortune.
 For I was the one who urged you on
 to kill your mother.

ORESTES

My lord Apollo,
 you have no knowledge how to be unjust.
 That being the case, now learn compassion, too.
 Your power to do good is strong enough.

APOLLO

Remember this—don't let fear defeat you
 by conquering your spirit. And you, Hermes,
 my own blood brother from a common father,
 protect this man. Live up to that name of yours,
 and be his guide. Since he's my suppliant,
 lead him as if you were his shepherd—
 remember Zeus respects an outcast's rights—
 with you to show the way, he'll get better,
 and quickly come among men once again.

110

[90]

[Exit Orestes. Apollo moves back into the inner sanctuary. Enter the Ghost of Clytaemnestra.]

GHOST OF CLYTAEMNESTRA *[addressing the sleeping chorus]*

Ah, you may be fast asleep, but now
 what use is sleeping? On account of you,
 I alone among the dead lack honour.
 The ghosts of those I killed revile me—
 they never stop. I wander in disgrace.
 They charge me with the most horrific crimes.
 But I, too, suffered cruelty from those
 most dear to me. And yet, although I died
 at the hands of one who killed his mother,
 no spirit is enraged on my behalf.
 Look here—you see these slashes on my heart?
 How did they get there? While it's asleep
 the mind can see, but in the light of day
 we have no vision of men's destiny.
 You've licked up many of my offerings,
 soothing milk and honey without wine.
 I've given many sacrificial gifts

120

[100]

130

with fire in my hearth at solemn banquets,
 in that night hour no god will ever share.
 I see all that being trampled underfoot. [110]
 He's gone, eluded you—just like a fawn,
 he's jumped the centre of your nets with ease. 140
 He mocks your efforts as he moves away.
 Listen to me. I'm speaking of my soul.
 So rouse yourselves! Wake up, you goddesses
 from underground. While you dream on I call—
 now Clytaemnestra summons you!

[The members of the Chorus begin to make strange sounds and to mutter in their sleep.]

You may well moan—the man's escaped. He's gone. [120]
 He's flown a long way off. The friends he has
 are stronger than my own. You sleep on there
 so heavily, no sense of my distress.
 Orestes, the man who killed his mother, 150
 has run off! You mutter, but keep sleeping.
 On your feet! Why won't you get up? What work
 has fate assigned you if not causing pain?
 Sleep and hard work, two apt confederates,
 have made these fearsome dragons impotent,
 draining all their rage.

CHORUS MEMBER *[muttering in her sleep]*

Seize him!
 Seize him! Seize him! Seize that man! Look out! [130]

GHOST OF CLYTAEMNESTRA

You hunt your prey, but only in your dreams,
 whimpering like hounds who never lose
 their keenness for the hunt. But you don't act! 160
 Get up! Don't let exhaustion beat you down.
 Sleep makes you soft—you overlook my pain.
 Let my reproaches justly prick your hearts,
 a spur for those who act with righteousness.
 Blow your blood-filled breath all over him.
 Let those fires in your bodies shrivel him.
 Go on! Drive him to a fresh pursuit. Go!

[The Furies begin to wake up slowly, one after the other. As they start to get up, the Ghost of Clytaemnestra exits.]

EUMENIDES

CHORUS LEADER *[waking up and rousing the other Furies]*

Wake up! Come on, I'll wake you up. [140]
Now do the same for her. Still sleeping?
Stand up. Wipe that sleep out of your eyes. 170
Let's chant our prelude—that should take effect.

[The Furies, now awake, gather as a group, moving around trying to find Orestes or smell his track. They speak these lines as individual members of the larger group.]

-Ah ha, what this? Dear sisters, something's wrong.

-I've been through a lot, and all for nothing.

-We're being made to suffer something bad,
alas, an evil we cannot endure.

-Our quarry's slipped our nets. He's gone!
Once sleep came over us, we lost our prey.

-You're disgraceful, Hermes, a child of Zeus
who loves to steal.

-For a god you're young— [150]
but still you trample on more ancient spirits. 180

-You showed that suppliant respect,
a godless man, so vicious to his parent.

-You may be a god, but you're a thief.
You filched a man who killed his mother.

-Who can say there's justice in such theft?

-In my dreams shame struck—
it came on like a charioteer
who gripped his cruel whip so tight,
then hit under my heart,
deep in my gut. 190

-I feel the executioner's scourge, [160]
the one who wields a heavy lash,
weighed down with pain.

-Younger gods are doing this—
they push their ruling power
beyond what's theirs by right.

Their throne drips blood
around its foot,
around its head.

-I see Earth's central navel stone
defiled with blood, corrupted,
stained with guilt.

200

-The prophet soils the hearth,
pollutes the shrine himself,
acting on his own behalf.
Against divine tradition,
he honours human things.

[170]

-He sets aside decrees of fate
established long ago.

-Though he inflicts his pain on me,
he'll never free that man.
Let him flee underground,
he'll find no liberty below.

210

-As he seeks to cleanse himself
he'll meet the next avenger—
a family member coming for his head.

[Enter Apollo from the inner part of the shrine.]

APOLLO

Get out! I'm ordering you to leave this house.
Move on! Out of my prophet's sanctuary!
Go now, or else you'll feel my arrows bite,
glittering winged snakes shot from a golden string.
Then, your agonies will make you choke,
spit out black froth you suck from men,
and vomit up the clotted blood you've drunk
from murder. This shrine's no place for you.
No, you belong where heads are sliced away,
eyes gouged out—where justice equals slaughter—
where youthful men are ruined by castration,

[180]

220

where others suffer mutilation, stoning,
 where men impaled on spikes below the spine
 scream all the time. That's the feast you love.
 You hear me? And that's why gods detest you.
 The way you look, your shape, says what you are—
 some blood-soaked lion's den might be your home.
 You must not infect those near this temple
 with your pollution. So leave this place,
 you flock without a shepherd, you herd
 the gods despise.

230 [190]

CHORUS LEADER

Lord Apollo,
 listen to what we say. It's our turn to speak.
 You're no mere accomplice in this crime—
 you did it all yourself. You bear the guilt.

240 [200]

APOLLO

What does that mean? Go on. Keep talking.

CHORUS LEADER

You told that stranger to kill his mother.

APOLLO

To avenge his father is what I said.
 What's wrong with that?

CHORUS LEADER

Then you supported him.
 You helped a man who'd just committed murder.

APOLLO

And I instructed him to come back here
 to expiate his crime.

CHORUS LEADER

Then why insult us,
 the ones who chased him here?

APOLLO

It's not right
 for you to come inside my shrine.

CHORUS LEADER

We've been assigned to do this.

APOLLO

Assigned?

250

What's that? Proclaim your fine authority.

CHORUS LEADER

We chase out of their homes those criminals
who slaughter their own mothers.

[210]

APOLLO

What about a wife who kills her husband?

CHORUS LEADER

That's not blood murder in the family.

APOLLO

What?

What about Zeus and his queen Hera—
your actions bring disgrace on them.
You ignore the strongest bonds between them.
Your claim dishonours Aphrodite, too,
goddess of love, from whom all men derive
their greatest joys. With man and woman
a marriage sealed by fate is stronger
than any oath, and justice guards it.
Now, if one partner kills the other one,
and you're not interested in punishment,
if you feel no urge to act, then I say
the way you chase Orestes is unjust.
I don't see why in one case you're so harsh
when you don't really care about the other.
However, goddess Athena will take charge—
she'll organize a trial.

260

[220]

270

CHORUS LEADER

But that fugitive—
he'll never be free of me, never.

APOLLO

Then go after him. Bring yourself more trouble.

CHORUS LEADER

Don't try to curb my powers with your words.

APOLLO

Your powers? Those I wouldn't take,
not even as a gift.

CHORUS LEADER

Of course not.

You're already great, by all accounts—
right by Zeus's throne. But for my part,
since I'm called onward by a mother's blood,
I'll chase this man with justice of my own.
I scent the trail!

[230]

280

APOLLO

I'll help my suppliant
and bring him safely home. With gods and men
the anger of a man who seeks redemption
will be dreadful, if, of my own free will,
I abandon him.

[Apollo exits into the inner shrine. The scene now changes to Athens, just outside the Temple of Athena. Orestes enters and moves up to the large statue of Athena.]

ORESTES

Queen Athena,

I've come here on Apollo's orders.
I beg your kindness. Please let me enter,
a man accursed, an outcast. I don't seek
ritual purification—my hands are clean—
but my avenging zeal has lost its edge,
worn down, blunted by other people's homes,
by all well-beaten pathways known to men.
I've stayed true to what Apollo told me
at his oracle. Crossing land and sea,
I've reached this statue by your shrine at last.
Here I take up my position, goddess.
I await the outcome of my trial.

290

[240]

[Enter the Furies, like hunting dogs, still tracking Orestes by his scent. They do not see him at first.]

CHORUS LEADER

Ah ha! Here we have that man's clear scent,
 a silent witness, but firm evidence.
 After him! Like hounds chasing a wounded fawn, 300
 we track him by the drops of blood he sheds.
 Man-killing work—the effort wearies me.
 My lungs are bursting. We've roamed everywhere,
 exploring all the regions of the earth,
 crossing seas in wingless flight, moving on [250]
 faster than any ship, always in pursuit.
 Now he's cornered here, cowering somewhere.
 I smell human blood—I could laugh for joy!
 Start looking for him! Seek him out again!
 Check everywhere. Don't let him escape. 310
 That man killed his mother—he must pay!

[The Chorus of Furies catch sight of Orestes and crowd around him.]

CHORUS *[different individuals]*

—He's over there! Claiming sanctuary,
 at that statue of the eternal goddess,
 embracing it. He must want a trial,
 a judgment on his murderous violence. [260]

—Impossible! A mother's blood, once shed,
 soaks in the earth and can't come back again—
 the flowing stream moves through the ground,
 then disappears forever.

—No. You must pay me back.
 I'll suck your blood. 320
 Drinking your living bones sustains me—
 I feed upon your pain.

—Though it wears me out, I'll drag you down,
 still living, to the world below. And there
 you'll pay for murdering your mother.

—You'll see there other human criminals
 who've failed to honour gods and strangers, [270]
 who've abused the parents they should love.
 They all receive the justice they deserve.

—Hades, mighty god of all the dead, 330
 judges mortal men below the ground.
 His perceptive mind records all things.

ORESTES

My misery has been my teacher—
 I know that men are cleansed in many ways,
 that sometimes it's appropriate to speak,
 sometimes to stay silent. And in this case
 a wise master has ordered me to speak.
 Blood on my hands is dormant now, fading— [280]
 polluting stains from my mother's murder
 have been washed away. When they were fresh, 340
 Apollo in his temple cleansed my guilt—
 slaughtering pigs to make me pure again.
 It's a long story to describe for you,
 right from the start, all the men I've seen,
 ones I've stayed with, then left unharmed.
 Time destroys all things which age with time.
 Now, with full reverence and holy speech,
 I invoke Athena, this country's queen.
 I beg her help. Let her appear unarmed.
 She'll win true allies in me, my land, 350 [290]
 the Argive people. We'll trust her forever.
 No matter where she is—in Libya,
 in some region by the springs of Triton,
 her birthplace, with her covered feet at rest,
 or on the move, assisting those she loves,
 or whether, like some bold commander
 in the Phelegraeon plain, battle site
 of gods and giants, she surveys the field—
 I pray she'll come, for she's a goddess
 and hears me, even though she's far away. 360
 May she come here. May she deliver me.

CHORUS LEADER

But Apollo's power will not save you—
 nor will Athena's. You're slated to die [300]
 abandoned and alone, without a sense
 of heartfelt joy, a bloodless criminal
 sucked dry by demons, just a shade—no more.

[Orestes makes no answer.]

What? You ignore my words and won't reply,
 you, a victim fattened up for me,
 my consecrated gift? You'll not perish
 on any altar—no, I'll eat you alive.

370

[Orestes continues to remain silent.]

All right then, hear our song, a spell to chain you.

CHORUS

Come, let's link our arms and dance—
 Furies determined to display
 our fearful art, to demonstrate
 collective power we possess
 to guide all mortals' lives.

[310]

We claim we represent true justice.
 Our anger never works against
 a man whose hands are clean—
 all his life he stays unharmed.
 But those men guilty of some crime,
 as this one is, who hide away,
 concealing blood-stained hands—
 we harass them as testament
 to those they've murdered.
 Blood avengers, always in pursuit,
 we chase them to the end.

380

[320]

Hear me, Mother Night,
 mother who gave birth to me
 so I could avenge
 the living and the dead.
 Leto's child, Apollo,
 dishonours me—he tears
 that man out of my hands,
 the hare who cowers there,
 who by rights must expiate
 his mother's blood.

390

Let this frenzied song of ours
 fall upon our victim's head,
 our sacrifice—our frenzy
 driving him to madness—
 obliterate his mind.

400

[330]

This is our Furies' chant
 It chains up the soul,
 destroys its harmony,
 and withers mortal men.

Remorseless Fate gave us this work
 to carry on forever, a destiny
 spun out for us alone,
 to attach ourselves to those 410
 who, overcome with passion,
 slaughter blood relatives.
 We chase after them until the end,
 until they go beneath the ground.
 In death they find small freedom. [340]

Let this frenzied song of ours
 fall upon our victim's head,
 our sacrifice—our frenzy
 driving him to madness—
 obliterate his mind. 420
 This is our Furies' chant.
 It chains up the soul,
 destroys its harmony,
 and withers mortal men.

These rights are ours from birth—
 even the immortal gods [350]
 may not lay hands on us.
 We share no feasts with them,
 no fellowship—their pure white robes
 are no part of our destiny. 430

The task I take upon myself is mine,
 to overthrow whole families,
 when strife inside the home
 kills someone near and dear.
 We chase that murderer down,
 the one who's spilled fresh blood.
 For all his strength, we wear him down.

That's why we're now here,
 eager to contest the charge,
 to challenge other gods, 440 [360]
 to make sure none of them

ends up controlling what is ours.
 There will be no trial—
 for Zeus despises us,
 considers us unworthy,
 refusing to converse with us
 because we deal in blood.

The task I take upon myself is mine,
 to overthrow whole families,
 when strife inside the home
 kills someone near and dear. 450
 We chase that murderer down,
 the one who's spilled fresh blood.
 For all his strength, we wear him down.

Those proud opinions people have,
 who raise themselves so high,
 who puff themselves to heaven,
 will melt away, dissolving
 in dishonour underground,
 when we, in our black robes, 460
 beat out our vengeful dance— [370]
 when we launch our attack.

Leaping from the heights,
 we pound them with our feet—
 our force trips up the runner
 as he sprints for home,
 a fate he cannot bear.
 His mind is so confused
 he does not sense his fall.
 Dark clouds of his defilement 470
 hover all around the man.
 Murky shadows fall,
 enveloping his home—
 and Rumour spreads
 a tale of sorrow. [380]

Leaping from the heights,
 we pound them with our feet—
 our force trips up the runner
 as he sprints for home,
 a fate he cannot bear. 480

So things remain.
 We have our skills—
 our powers we fulfill,
 keeping human evil in our minds.
 Our awesome powers
 cannot be appeased by men.
 Dishonoured and despised,
 we see our work gets done.
 Split off from gods,
 with no light from the sun,
 we make the path more arduous
 for those who still can see
 and for the blind.

490

What man is not in awe
 or stands there unafraid
 to hear me state my rights,
 those powers allowed by Fate
 and ratified by all the gods,
 mine to hold forever?

[390]

Those old prerogatives
 I still retain—they're mine.
 I have my honour, too,
 though my appointed place
 is underneath the ground
 in sunless darkness.

500

[Enter Athena.]

ATHENA

I heard someone summon me from far away.
 I was in Troy, by the Scamander's banks,
 taking ownership of new property,
 a gift from ruling leaders of Achaea,
 a major part of what their spears had won,
 assigned to me entirely and forever,
 a splendid gift for Theseus's sons.
 I've come from there at my untiring pace,
 not flying on wings, but on this whirling cape,
 a chariot yoked to horses in their prime.
 Here I see an unfamiliar crowd,
 strangers to this place, nothing I fear,
 but astonishing to see. Who are you?

510 [400]

I'm talking to all those assembled here—
 the stranger crouching there beside my statue, 520
 and those of you like no one ever born, [410]
 creatures no god has seen in goddesses,
 in form a thing unknown to mortal men.
 But to say such things about one's neighbour
 who's done no wrong is far from just
 and contravenes our customs.

CHORUS LEADER

Daughter of Zeus,
 you'll find out everything—and briefly, too.
 We are immortal children of the Night.
 Below ground, where we have our homes,
 we're called the Curses.

ATHENA

Now I know your race 530
 I know what people call you.

CHORUS LEADER

But our powers—
 these you'll quickly ascertain as well.

ATHENA

Those I'd like to learn. Please state them clearly. [420]

CHORUS LEADER

We hound out of their homes all those who kill.

ATHENA

Once the killer flees, where does he finally go?

CHORUS LEADER

Where no one thinks of joy, for there is none.

ATHENA

Your screams would drive this man to such a flight?

CHORUS LEADER

Yes—he thought it right to kill his mother.

ATHENA

Why? Was he forced to do it? Did he fear
another person's anger?

CHORUS LEADER

Where's the urge
so strong to force a man to kill his mother?

540

ATHENA

There are two sides to this dispute. I've heard
only one half the argument.

CHORUS LEADER

What about the oath?
He won't deny he did it or accept
the guilt we charge him with.

ATHENA

Where do you stand?
You wish to be considered righteous,
but not to act with justice.

[430]

CHORUS LEADER

How? Teach me.
You clearly have a mind for subtleties.

ATHENA

I assert that no one should use oaths
to let injustice triumph.

CHORUS LEADER

Question him.
Then make a righteous judgment.

550

ATHENA

Are you prepared
that I should be the one to do this,
to produce a final verdict?

CHORUS LEADER

Why not?
We respect your worth, as you do ours.

ATHENA

Stranger, do you have anything to say
 by way of a response? State your country,
 lineage, and circumstance. And then,
 defend yourself against their accusations,
 if you really trust the justice of your case,
 as you sit here clinging to my statue, 560
 a sacred suppliant beside my hearth, [440]
 doing what Ixion did so long ago.¹
 Speak to me. Address all this directly.

ORESTES

Queen Athena, your last words express
 important doubts which I must first remove.
 I'm not a suppliant in need of cleansing.
 Nor have I fallen at your statue's feet
 with my hands defiled. On these two points
 I'll offer weighty proof. Our laws assert
 a criminal polluted with blood guilt 570
 will be denied all speech until he's cleansed
 by someone authorized to purify
 a man for murder, who sprinkles him
 with suckling victim's blood. Some time ago, [450]
 in homes of other men, I underwent
 such purification rites with slaughtered beasts,
 at flowing streams, as well. So, as I say,
 there are no grounds for your misgivings here.
 As for my family, you'll know that soon enough—
 I'm an Argive, son of Agamemnon. 580
 You may well ask his story—he's the man
 who put that naval force together.
 You worked with him to see that Ilion,
 Troy's city, ceased to be. When he came home,
 he died in a disgraceful way, butchered
 by my mother, whose black heart snagged him [460]
 in devious hunting nets—these still exist,
 attesting to that slaughter in his bath.
 I was in exile at the time. I came back.
 I killed my mother—that I don't deny— 590
 to avenge the murder of my father,

¹Ixion murdered his father-in-law and became an outcast as a result. But Zeus forgave him and brought him to Olympus. There Ixion had sexual designs on Zeus's wife, Hera. Zeus punished him by attaching him to a wheel of fire and placing him eternally in Hades.

whom I truly loved. For this murder
 Apollo bears responsibility,
 along with me. He urged me to it,
 pointing out the cruel reprisals I would face
 if I failed to act against the murderers.
 Was what I did a righteous act or not?
 That you must decide. I'll be satisfied,
 no matter how you render judgment.

ATHENA

This is a serious matter, too complex
 for any mortal man to think of judging. 600 [470]
 It's not right even for me to adjudicate
 such cases, where murder done in passion
 merits passionate swift punishment.
 Above all, you come here a suppliant
 who's gone through all cleansing rituals,
 who's pure and hence no danger to my shrine.
 You thus have my respect, for in my view,
 where my city is concerned, you're innocent.
 But these Furies also have their function. 610
 That's something we just cannot set aside.
 So if they fail to triumph in this case,
 they'll spread their poisonous resentment—
 it will seep underground, infecting us,
 bring perpetual disease upon our land,
 something we can't bear. So stands the case. [480]
 Two options, each of them disastrous.
 Allow one to remain, expel the other?
 No, I see no way of resolving this.
 But since the judgment now devolves on me, 620
 I'll appoint human judges of this murder,
 a tribunal bound by oath—I'll set it up
 to last forever. So you two parties,
 summon your witnesses, set out your proofs,
 with sworn evidence to back your stories.
 Once I've picked the finest men in Athens,
 I'll return. They'll rule fairly in this case,
 bound by a sworn oath to act with justice.

[Exit Athena.]

CHORUS

If his legal action triumphs, [490]

if now this matricide prevails,
 then newly set divine decrees
 will overthrow all order.
 Mortals will at once believe
 that everything's permitted.
 From now on parents can expect
 repeated blows of suffering
 inflicted by their children—
 now and in time yet to come.

630

For Furies who keep watch on men
 will bring no anger down
 on human crimes—so then
 we loose death everywhere,
 all forms of killing known to man.
 So one, seeing his neighbour's pain,
 will ask another, "Where's this end?
 When does our suffering diminish?"
 But the poor wretch can offer nothing—
 his remedies are vain, without effect.

640 [500]

So when a terrible disaster strikes
 let no one make the old appeal,
 "Justice, you Furies—hear me,
 you powers on your thrones!"
 It may well happen soon—
 a father in despair, a mother
 in some new catastrophe,
 may scream out for pity,
 now the house of justice falls.

650 [510]

Sometimes what's terrible can work
 to bring about what's good.
 Such terror needs to sit on guard,
 to check the passionate heart.
 There is a benefit for men
 to learn control through suffering.
 For where is there a man or city—
 both alike in this regard—
 who still respects what's just
 without a heart attuned to fear?

660

[520]

It's not right that men revere
 a life without controls

or one enslaved by tyrants. 670
 Those who practise moderation
 in everything they do
 acquire strength from god, [530]
 though he hands down
 his other gifts in other ways.

Our words stress self-control,
 for arrogance, we know,
 is surely born from sacrilege.
 From a healthy heart and mind
 comes the happiness men love, 680
 the joy they ask for in their prayers.

To sum up everything about this case,
 I'll tell you this—Justice has an altar.
 Give that full human reverence.
 Don't trample it profanely underfoot [540]
 because self-interest sees advantages.
 Remember punishment will come—
 that outcome's fixed and permanent.
 So each of you, above all else,
 should honour parents, 690
 pay them the deference you owe,
 respect all guests and strangers
 you welcome in your home.

For happiness will never fail [550]
 the man who follows justice,
 freely and without constraint.
 He'll never be destroyed.
 But the reckless man who goes too far,
 who piles up riches for himself
 in any way he can and disregards 700
 all justice—I tell you this—
 in time he'll have to strike his sail,
 as storming torments break his ship
 and his yardarm shatters.

He screams for help.
 But no one listens.
 In the middle of the seas
 he fights—but all in vain.
 Whirlpools suck him down,

while heaven roars with laughter
 at the sight of this hot-tempered man
 who used to boast with pride
 he'd never come to grief
 now helpless, panic stricken,
 unable to ride out the waves.
 He always lived for wealth—
 now that, too, smashes on the reef,
 the rock of Justice—he drowns,
 unseen and unlamented.

710 [560]

[The scene shifts to the Areopagus, the high court of Athens. Athena enters with a herald and ten citizens, the jury she has selected. A crowd of citizens enters with her. Orestes moves to the place where the accused stands.]

ATHENA

Herald, blow the call for order in this court.
 Raise that Etruscan trumpet, fill your lungs,
 let these people hear an ear-piercing blast.
 As they crowd into this court of judgment
 it's better to have silence. The whole city
 can listen to my laws, which are eternal.
 So can these litigants. Then all will see
 the justice in our verdict for themselves.

720

[570]

[Enter Apollo. He moves to stand behind Orestes.]

Lord Apollo, you have your own domain.
 What's your role here? Announce that to us.

APOLLO

I've come here as a witness. That man,
 the accused, according to our customs,
 came a suppliant to my shrine, my hearth.
 I purified him of the blood he spilled.
 As his advocate, I share the blame
 arising from his mother's murder.
 Start the trial. You understand procedure.
 Confirm that with a just decision.

730

[580]

ATHENA *[addressing the Furies]*

Then I'll begin the trial. You speak up first.
 The plaintiff opens our proceedings.

Tell us the facts. Begin at the beginning—
inform us clearly of the issues here.

740

CHORUS LEADER

There are many of us, but we'll keep
our speeches brief.

[Turning to interrogate Orestes.]

Answer our questions,
as we put them one by one. First, tell us—
did you kill your mother?

ORESTES

Yes, I killed her.
I don't deny the fact.

CHORUS LEADER

We take first fall.
Three falls wins the match.

ORESTES

You gloat,
but your opponent isn't pinned down yet.

[590]

CHORUS LEADER

Now you must describe the murder for us.
How did you kill her?

ORESTES

I'll tell you—
I drew my sword and slit her throat.

750

CHORUS LEADER

Who persuaded you to do this? Whose advice?

ORESTES

The orders of this god. He is my witness.

CHORUS LEADER

The prophet ordered you to kill your mother?

ORESTES

He did. And to this moment I have no regrets.

CHORUS LEADER

But if the verdict lays its hands on you,
you'll change your story soon enough.

ORESTES

I'm confident. My father from his grave
will send the help I need.

CHORUS LEADER

So you trust the dead,
and yet you killed your mother?

760

ORESTES

I do, for she was guilty of two crimes.

[600]

CHORUS LEADER

How so? Inform the judges on this point.

ORESTES

She killed her husband and my father.

CHORUS LEADER

But her death evens out the score for her.
You're still living.

ORESTES

When she was still alive
you didn't hound her into exile. Why?

CHORUS LEADER

She and her victim shared no common blood.

ORESTES

And my mother and me? Are we blood linked?

CHORUS LEADER

How else could she sustain you in her womb,
you murderer? Do you now reject
the closest bond there is, a mother's blood?

770

ORESTES *[turning to Apollo]*

You must give evidence, Apollo.
Take the lead for me. Did I kill her justly?

[610]

For I don't deny I did the murder.
 But whether that act of shedding blood
 was just or not, as you perceive the facts,
 you must decide, so I can tell the court.

APOLLO

Let me address this high court of Athena.
 Tribunal members, what I have to say
 will proceed from justice. I'm a prophet. 780
 I cannot tell a lie. And never yet,
 when I've been seated in my oracle,
 have I said anything in prophecy
 concerning woman, man, or city state,
 that Olympian father Zeus did not command.
 Make sure you understand how powerful
 his justice is. That's why I urge you now— [620]
 obey the will of Zeus, our father.
 No oath has greater strength than Zeus.

CHORUS LEADER

Then, Zeus, according to your reasoning, 790
 told your oracle to give the order—
 Orestes must avenge his father's death,
 ignoring any rights his mother had.

APOLLO

Yes. For these two things are not the same—
 he died a noble man, a special king
 who bears a sceptre given by the gods,
 an honoured king who dies by murder,
 and at a woman's hand, not in a fight
 where arrows fly in from a distance,
 as with the Amazons, but in a way 800
 which we'll describe for you, Athena,
 and those here ready to decide this case
 when you cast your votes. He'd just come home, [630]
 returning from a long and harsh campaign,
 where in the eyes of loyal citizens
 he'd won success beyond all expectation.
 She welcomed him. Then, he took his bath.
 As he stepped out—still on the outer rim—
 she threw the cloak, his shroud, around him,
 just like a tent. She caught him in those robes, 810
 whose endless folds enclosed him like a net.

Then she hacked him down. I'm telling you,
that's how the splendid leader of the ships
went to his death. As for that woman,
I speak of her to rouse a sense of shame
in those men chosen here to judge this case.

CHORUS

So your claim is Zeus thinks a father's death [640]
is more significant? But on his own
he chained up his old father, Cronos.
Does that not contradict what you've just said? 820
I ask you judges to take note of this.

APOLLO

You monsters—how all the gods detest you!
Zeus has power to smash those chains apart.
For that he has a remedy, many ways
to set us free. But once a mortal's blood
has drained into the dust, the man is dead.
And then there's no return. My father Zeus
has made no charms for that, though he can change [650]
all other things without a pause for breath.

CHORUS LEADER

You plead to set him free. But think of this— 830
will this man, who shed his mother's blood,
who spilled it on the ground, return back home,
to live in Argos in his father's house?
Where are the public altars he can use,
the family cleansing rites he can attend?

APOLLO

I'll speak to that, as well. Make sure you note
how right my answer is. That word mother—
we give it to the one who bears the child.
However, she's no parent, just a nurse
to that new life embedded in her. 840
The parent is the one who plants the seed,
the father. Like a stranger for a stranger, [660]
she preserves the growing life, unless
god injures it. And I can offer proof
for what I say—a man can have a child
without a mother. Here's our witness,
here—Athena, child of Olympian Zeus.

[Apollo points to Athena.]

No dark womb nursed her—no goddess bears
 a child with ancestry like hers.² Athena,
 since I know so many other things, 850
 I'll make your city and your people great.
 That's why I sent this man a suppliant
 to your own shrine, so he might prove himself,
 then place eternal trust in you, dear goddess, [670]
 and you could win a new ally in him,
 in his descendants, too, and thus create
 an everlasting bond with his posterity.

ATHENA

Has each side said enough? Shall I now
 instruct the judges to cast their votes,
 acting on their judgment of what's just? 860

CHORUS LEADER

Though we've already shot our final arrow,
 we'll stay to hear this contest to the end.

ATHENA

Why not? Now, as for you defendants,
 what can I do to avoid your censure?

APOLLO

You have heard what you have heard.

[To jurors.]

My friends,
 as you cast your ballots, make sure your hearts [680]
 respect that oath you made.

ATHENA

You citizens of Athens, you judges
 at the first trial ever held for murder,
 hear what I decree. Now and forever 870
 this court of judges will be set up here
 to serve Aegeus's people. This place,
 this Mount of Ares, is where Amazons,

²According to an old tradition, Athena had no mother. She sprang fully grown out of Zeus's head .

once marched in force, enraged at Theseus.
 Here they pitched their tents. Then they built
 a new city on the heights, with lofty walls
 to match his own, making a sacrifice
 to Ares, god of war, from whom this rock
 derives its name, the Mount of Ares. [690]
 From this hill Reverence and Terror, 880
 two kindred rulers of my citizens,
 will guarantee they don't commit injustice,
 by day or night, unless the citizens
 pollute the laws with evil innovations.
 Once limpid waters are stained with mud,
 you'll never find a drink. My people,
 avoid both anarchy and tyranny.
 I urge you to uphold this principle.
 Show it due reverence. As for terror,
 don't banish it completely from the city. 890
 What mortal man is truly righteous
 without being afraid? Those who sense the fear [700]
 revere what's right. With citizens like these
 your country and your city will be safe,
 stronger than anything possessed by men
 in Pelops' country or in Scythia.
 So here I now establish this tribunal,
 incorruptible and magnificent,
 swift in punishment—it stands above you,
 your country's guardian as you lie asleep. 900
 I've gone through this at length to urge you on,
 my citizens, today and in the future.
 But now you must get up, cast your ballots,
 decide this case, while honouring your oath. [710]
 I'm finished—that's all I have to say.

[The members of the tribunal begin to step forward and cast their votes into the urns.]

CHORUS LEADER

Watch out. Don't ever show us disrespect.
 For our united power can crush your land.

APOLLO

Let me remind you—fear the oracles,
 not just mine, but those of Zeus the Father.
 Don't make them barren.

CHORUS LEADER *[to Apollo]*

You interfere 910

in blood work that's not your proper business.
Your oracles remain no longer pure.

APOLLO

When the first man-killer Ixion
went a suppliant to Zeus for cleansing,
was Zeus wrong to treat him as he did?

CHORUS LEADER

Argue all you want. But in this judgment
if I don't prevail, I'll be back again [720]
to bring this country to its knees.

APOLLO

Among all gods, old and new alike,
you have no honour. I will triumph here. 920

CHORUS LEADER

Just as you triumphed in the house of Pheres,
persuading Fate to free all men from death.³

APOLLO

Surely it's right to help a worshipper,
especially when his need is desperate?

CHORUS LEADER

You made those ancient goddesses, the Fates,
drunk on wine, then got them to suspend
the oldest rule of order we possess.

APOLLO

Well, you'll soon lose this case. Then you can spew
your poison and not hurt your enemies. [730]

CHORUS

You're young. You'd ride roughshod over me 930
because I'm old. I'll await the verdict,
see where this trial ends. I have my doubts
about my anger at this city.

³The Furies cite this case as a time when Apollo interfered with the inevitability of death by allowing Admetus to purchase freedom from his own fate by substituting someone else.

ATHENA

It's now my task to give my final verdict.
 And I award my ballot to Orestes.
 No mother gave me birth—that's why
 in everything but marriage I support
 the man with all my heart, a true child
 of my father Zeus. Thus, that woman's death
 I won't consider more significant.
 She killed her husband, guardian of their home.
 If the votes are equal, Orestes wins.
 Now, members of the jury, do your job.
 Shake the ballots from the urns—and quickly.

940

[740]

[The urns are emptied and the ballots counted.]

ORESTES

O Phoebus Apollo, how did they vote?

CHORUS

O black mother Night, are you watching this?

ORESTES

Now for the result. Either I hang
 or live on to see the light of day.

CHORUS

Either we're finished or our honour thrives.

APOLLO

Shake out all ballots, friends. Count them fairly.
 Divide them with due care. Make no mistakes.
 Errors in judgment now can mean disaster.
 A single ballot cast can save this house.

950

[750]

[The ballots are shown to Athena.]

ATHENA

The numbers of the votes are equal—thus,
 this man's acquitted of the murder charge.

ORESTES

O Pallas Athena, you've saved my house.
 I'd lost my homeland—now you give it back,
 and anyone in Greece can say, "This man

is once again an Argive, occupying
 his father's property, thanks to Pallas, 960
 thanks to Apollo, and thanks to Zeus,
 third god and all-fulfilling saviour." [760]
 Faced with these pleaders for my mother's cause,
 Zeus chose to honour my father's death.
 Now I'll go home. But first I make this oath
 to your land and people for all time to come—
 never will an Argive leader march in here
 with spears arrayed against you. If he does,
 in violation of this oath of mine,
 from the grave we'll see his effort fails. 970
 We'll bring him bad luck, trouble on the march, [770]
 send birds of evil omen over him.
 He'll regret the pains his campaign brings him.
 But all those who keep this oath, who honour
 for all time Athena's city, allies
 who fight on its behalf, such citizens
 we'll treat with greater favour and good will.
 And so farewell to you, Athena,
 farewell to those who guard your city.
 In struggles with your enemies, I hope 980
 you catch them in a stranglehold, win out,
 and gain the spear denoting victory.

[Apollo and Orestes leave. The Furies move to surround Athena.]

CHORUS

You younger gods, you've wrenched our ancient laws
 out of my grasp, then stamped them underfoot.
 You heap on us dishonourable contempt. [780]
 Now my anger turns against this land
 I'll spread my poisons—how it's going to pay,
 when I release this venom in my heart
 to ease my grief. I'll saturate this ground.
 It won't survive. From it disease will grow, 990
 infecting leaves and children—that's justice.
 Sterility will spread across the land,
 contaminate the soil, destroy mankind.
 What can I do now but scream out in pain?
 The citizens make fun of us, the Furies. [790]
 How can we put up with such indignity,
 daughters of Night disgracefully abused,
 dishonoured, shamed, our powers cast aside?

ATHENA

Let me persuade you not to spurn this trial.
 You've not been beaten—the votes were fair, 1000
 the numbers equal, no disgrace to you.
 But we received clear evidence from Zeus.
 The one who spoke the oracle declared
 Orestes should not suffer for his act.
 So don't be vengeful, breathing anger [800]
 on this land and drenching it with showers,
 whose drops, like spears, will kill the seeds,
 and blast its fruitfulness. I promise you
 in all righteousness you'll have your place,
 a subterranean cavern, yours by right. 1010
 Beside the hearth you'll sit on glittering thrones,
 worshipped with reverence by my citizens.

CHORUS

You younger gods, you've wrenched our ancient laws
 out of my grasp, then stamped them underfoot.
 You heap on us dishonourable contempt. [810]
 Now my anger turns against this land
 I'll spread my poisons—how it's going to pay,
 when I release this venom in my heart
 to ease my grief. I'll saturate this ground.
 It won't survive. From it disease will grow, 1020
 infecting leaves and children—that's justice.
 Sterility will spread across the land,
 contaminate the soil, destroy mankind.
 What can I do now but scream out in pain?
 The citizens make fun of us, the Furies.
 How can we put up with such indignity, [820]
 daughters of Night disgracefully abused,
 shamed, dishonoured, our powers cast aside?

ATHENA

But you've not lost honour—you're goddesses.
 Don't let your anger lead you to excess, 1030
 to blast this land of men past remedy.
 I have faith in Zeus. Why must I mention that?
 Well, I'm the only god who knows the keys
 to Zeus's arsenal where he keeps sealed
 his lightning bolt. But there's no need for that.
 Accept my argument. Don't let rash tongues [830]
 hurl threats against this land, condemning it

to sterile fruitlessness. Ease your anger.
 Let your fury's black and bitter waves recede.
 You can live with me, receive full honours. 1040
 The first fruits of this fertile land are yours,
 forever, all those offerings for heirs,
 for marriages—from now on they're yours.
 With all this, you'll praise what I'm advising.

CHORUS

Such suffering for me.
 My ancient wisdom
 driven underground,
 despised, dishonoured.
 The shame, my shame.
 This pure rage I breathe 1050 [840]
 consumes me utterly.
 What sinks under my ribs
 and pains my heart?

O Night, my mother,
 the cunning of those gods,
 too hard to overcome,
 takes all my ancient powers,
 and leaves me nothing.

ATHENA

I'll bear with your rage, for you are older,
 and thus your wisdom far exceeds my own. 1060
 But Zeus gave me a fine intelligence as well. [850]
 So let me tell you this—if you leave here,
 for this land you'll feel a lover's yearning.
 As time goes on, my citizens will win
 increasing honour, and you, on your thrones,
 seated outside the house of Erechtheus,
 a place of honour, will win more respect
 from lines of men and women filing past
 than you could find in all the world beyond.⁴
 So cast no stones for bloodshed on this land, 1070
 my realm. Do not corrupt our youthful hearts,
 intoxicating them with rage, like wine, [860]
 or rip the heart out of a fighting cock

⁴Erechtheus was a legendary king of Athens.

to set it in my people, giving them
 a thirst for reckless internecine war.
 Let them fight wars abroad, without restraint
 in those men driven by a lust for fame.
 I want no birds who fight their wars at home.
 That's what I offer you. It's yours to take.
 Do good things, receive good things in honour. 1080
 Take your place in a land the gods all love.

CHORUS

Such suffering for me— [870]
 my ancient wisdom
 driven underground,
 despised, dishonoured.
 The shame, my shame.
 This pure rage I breathe
 consumes me utterly.
 What sinks under my ribs
 and pains my heart? 1090
 O Night, my mother,
 the cunning of those gods,
 too hard to overcome,
 takes all my ancient powers,
 and leaves me nothing. [880]

ATHENA

I'll not tire of telling you your gifts,
 so you can never lodge complaints that I,
 a newer god, or men who guard this land
 failed to revere such ancient goddesses
 and cast you out in exile from our city. 1100
 No. But if you respect Persuasion,
 holding in reverence that sacred power
 whose soothing spell sits on my tongue,
 then you should stay. If that's not your wish,
 it would be unjust to vent your anger
 on this city, injuring its people,
 enraged at them from spite. It's up to you—
 take your allotted portion of this land, [890]
 justly entitled to your share of honour.

CHORUS LEADER

Queen Athena, this place you say is ours, 1110
 what exactly is it?

ATHENA

One free of pain,
without anxieties. Why not accept?

CHORUS LEADER

If I do, what honours would I get?

ATHENA

Without you no house can thrive.

CHORUS LEADER

You'd do this? You'd grant me that much power?

ATHENA

I will. Together we'll enrich the lives
of all who worship us.

CHORUS LEADER

This promise you make—
you'll hold to it forever?

ATHENA

Yes I will.
I don't say anything I don't fulfill.

CHORUS LEADER

Your magic's doing its work, it seems—
I feel my rage diminish.

1120 [900]

ATHENA

Then stay.
In this land you'll win more friends.

CHORUS LEADER

Let me speak out a blessing on the land.
Tell me what I might say.

ATHENA

Speak nothing
of brutal victories—only blessings
stemming from the earth, the ocean depths,
the heavens. Let gusting winds caress the land
in glorious sunlight, our herds and harvests
overflow with plenty, so they never fail

our citizens in time to come, whose seed
 will last forever. Let their prosperity
 match how well they worship you. I love
 these righteous men, the way a gardener loves
 his growing plants, this race now free of grief.
 These things are yours to give. For my part,
 I'll see this city wins triumphal fame
 in deadly wars where men seek glory,
 so all men celebrate victorious Athens.

1130

[910]

CHORUS

Then we'll accept this home
 and live here with Athena.
 We'll never harm a place
 which she and Ares
 and all-powerful Zeus
 hold as a fortress of the gods,
 this glorious altar, the shield
 for all the gods of Greece.
 I make this prayer for Athens,
 prophesying fine things for her—
 bounteous happy harvests
 bursting from the earth,
 beneath a radiant sun.

1140

[920]

1150

ATHENA

To all my citizens I'll act with kindness,
 setting in place these goddesses among them—
 powerful divinities, implacable—
 whose office is to guide all mortals' lives
 in everything they do. If there's a man
 who's never felt their weight, he's ignorant
 of where life's blows arise. His father's crimes
 drag him before these goddesses, and there,
 for all his boasting, his destruction comes—
 dread silent anger crushing him to dust.

[930]

1160

CHORUS

Hear me speak my blessing—
 let no winds destroy the trees
 nor scorching desert heat move in
 to shrivel budding plants,
 no festering blight kill off the fruit.
 May Pan foster fertility

[940]

and make the flocks increase,
 to every ewe twin lambs,
 all born in season, and in Athens
 may the earth be rich in treasure,
 paying fine gifts to Hermes,
 god of unexpected luck.

ATHENA

Do you hear that, you guardians of my city?
 The blessings they will bring? They're powerful,
 the sacred Furies, among immortal gods,
 among the dead below. With mortal men
 it's clear they work their wills decisively,
 for some a life of song, for others lives of tears.

CHORUS

I forbid those deadly accidents
 which cut men down before their time.
 And all you gods with rightful powers,
 let our lovely girls all live
 to find a husband. Hear our prayers,
 you sacred Fates, our sisters,
 you children of the Night,
 who apportion all things justly,
 who have a place in every home,
 whose righteous visitations
 at all times carry weight, everywhere
 most honoured of the gods.

ATHENA

I rejoice to hear these love-filled blessings
 conferred upon this land. It pleases me
 Persuasion kept watch on my tongue and lips,
 when I met their fierce refusal. But Zeus,
 the patron god of our assemblies,
 has triumphed. Our struggle here for justice
 has left us victorious forever.

CHORUS

I pray man-killing civil strife
 may never roar aloud
 within the city—may its dust
 not drink our citizen's dark blood,
 nor passions for revenge incite

those wars which kill the state.
 Let men give joy for joy,
 united by their common love,
 united in their enmities—
 for that cures all human ills.

ATHENA

You see now how these Furies seek their way
 with well intentioned words? I can predict
 these terrifying faces will provide
 my citizens all sorts of benefits.
 So treat them kindly, just as they are kind.
 Worship them forever. Then you'll keep
 your land and city on the path of justice,
 in everything you do attaining glory.

1210

[990]

CHORUS

Rejoice, rejoice
 amid the riches you deserve
 rejoice, you citizens,
 who dwell with Zeus, 1220
 who love that virgin girl,
 Athena—and she loves you.
 You manifest your wisdom
 at the proper time, nestling
 underneath Athena's wings,
 while Zeus looks on in awe.

[1000]

[Enter a group of citizens to lead Athena's procession, some bearing unlit torches, some robes, and some leading animals for sacrifice.]

ATHENA

And you too rejoice. I must lead the way,
 show you to your rooms, by sacred torchlight
 carried by your escort. Now you can go—
 move with speed under the earth, and there
 with sacred sacrificial blood hold down
 what would destroy my land and send above
 what brings prosperity, so that our city
 may prove victorious. And now you citizens,
 you children of Cranaus, king of this rock,
 lead our new residents for life away.
 May all citizens look on with favour
 at those who bring such favours to them.

1230

[1010]

CHORUS

Farewell, once more farewell,
 all those who live in Athens, 1240
 gods and men, inhabitants
 of Pallas' city. Pay us respect,
 while we live here among you—
 you'll have cause to celebrate
 the fortunes of your lives. [1020]

ATHENA

My thanks to you for these words of blessing.
 Now I'll send you down by blazing torchlight
 to your homes beneath the earth, with this escort
 of those duty-bound to guard my statue.
 That seems right. For the most precious part 1250
 of all the land of Theseus will come out,
 a splendid throng of girls and mothers,
 groups of older women.

[From the processional company some women bearing scarlet robes move forward to place the robes on the Furies. Athena speaks directly to them.]

Invest these Furies
 with their special crimson robes. Honour them.
 Then, move on with the torches, so this group, [1030]
 our fellow residents, can show the love
 they bear this land, and for all time to come
 bring our city strength and great good fortune.

[The women dress the Furies in the scarlet robes and sing the final song of joy and thanks, as the entire procession of Athena, Furies, and citizens moves off stage.]

THE WOMEN OF ATHENS

Move on with your loyal escort,
 you mighty children of the Night, 1260
 children without children, no longer young,
 yet glorious in your honours.
 You citizens, nothing but blessings in your songs.

Deep in those primeval caverns
 far underground, our sacrifices,
 the sacred honours we bestow on you
 will maintain our city's reverence.
 All of you, nothing but blessings in your songs.

EUMENIDES

Come forward, sacred goddesses,
benevolent and gracious to our land,
come forward with the flaming torches,
rejoicing as we move along our way.
Now raise triumphal cries to crown our song!

[1040]

1270

Peace now reigns forevermore
between Athena's people and their guests.
For all-seeing Zeus and Fate herself
have worked together for this ending.
Now raise triumphal cries to crown our song!

[The entire group moves off singing and dancing.]

Aeschylus
LIBATION BEARERS
[CHOEPHOROI]

Translated by
Ian Johnaston
Vancouver Island University
Nanaimo, BC
Canada

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Note that in the following translation the line numbers in square brackets refer to the Greek text and the numbers without brackets refer to the English text. The footnotes and stage directions have been added by the translator.

In this translation, possessives of names ending in -s are usually indicated in the common way (that is, by adding -'s (e.g. *Zeus* and *Zeus's*). This convention adds a syllable to the spoken word (the sound -iz). Sometimes, for metrical reasons, this English text indicates such possession in an alternate manner, with a simple apostrophe. This form of the possessive does not add an extra syllable to the spoken name (e.g., *Orestes* and *Orestes'* are both three-syllable words).

LIBATION BEARERS

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

ORESTES: son of Agamemnon and Clytaemnestra, brother of Electra.

CHORUS: slave women captured at Troy and serving the royal palace at Argos.

ELECTRA: daughter of Agamemnon and Clytaemnestra, sister of Orestes.

SERVANT: house slave serving in the royal palace.

CLYTAEMNESTRA: widow of Agamemnon, lover of Aegisthus, mother of Orestes and Electra.

PYLADES: friend of Orestes.

CILISSA: Orestes's old nurse, a servant in the palace.

AEGISTHUS: son of Thyestes, lover of Clytaemnestra.¹

ATTENDANTS on Orestes and Pylades and Aegisthus.

[Scene: Argos, at the tomb of Agamemnon some years after his murder by Clytaemnestra and Aegisthus. Behind the tomb stands the royal palace of the sons of Atreus. Enter Orestes and Pylades. They have just arrived in Argos.]

ORESTES

Hermes, messenger to the dead, guardian
of your father's powers, help rescue me—
work with me, I beg you, now I've come back,
returned to this land from exile.² On this grave,
on this heaped-up earth, I call my father,
imploping him to listen, to hear me . . .

[Orestes cuts two locks of his hair and sets them one by one on the tomb.]

Here's a lock of hair, offering to Inachus,
the stream where I was raised. Here's another,
a token of my grief. I was not there,
my father, to mourn your death. I could not stretch 10
my hand out to you, when they carried off
your corpse for burial.

[Enter Electra and the Chorus, dressed in black. They do not see Orestes and Pylades.]

What's this I see? [10]

What's this crowd of women coming here,
all wearing black in public? What does it mean?
What new turn of fate? Has some fresh sorrow
struck the house? Or am I right to think

¹Thyestes, the father of Aegisthus, was the brother of Atreus, the father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

²Hermes, a divine son of Zeus, accompanied the dead down to Hades.

they bring libations here to honour you,
 my father, to appease the dead below?
 That must be it. I see my sister there,
 Electra. That's her approaching with them. 20
 She's grieving—in great pain—that's obvious.
 O Zeus, let me avenge my father's death.
 Support me as my ally in this fight.
 Pylades, let's stand over there and hide, [20]
 so I can find out what is taking place,
 what brings these suppliant women here.

[Orestes and Pylades conceal themselves from the sight of Electra and the Chorus]

CHORUS

I've been sent here from the palace,
 to bring libations for the dead,
 to clap out the hands' sharp beat.
 Blood flows down my cheeks 30
 from cuts my nails have scratched.
 As life drags on and on, my heart
 feeds itself on my laments,
 to the sound of garments torn apart,
 the sound of sorrow in our clothes,
 as we rip the woven linen
 covering our breasts.
 No laughter any more. [30]
 Our fortune beats us down.

With hair-raising shrieks, Fear, 40
 dream-prophet in this house,
 breathed a furious cry of terror,
 at night, while people were asleep.
 Deep within the inner house
 the heavy scream re-echoed, all the way
 to rooms where women slept.
 Those who read our dreams,
 who speak by heaven's will,
 declared, "The dead beneath the ground [40]
 are discontent—their anger grows 50
 against the ones who killed them."

O Earth, my mother Earth,
 to protect herself from harm
 that godless woman sends me here

with gifts, with loveless gifts.
 But I'm too scared to speak her words,
 the prayer she wishes me to say.
 What can atone for blood
 once fallen on the ground?
 Alas for the grief-filled hearth,
 Alas for the buried home!
 Sunless darkness grips the house
 which all men hate, for now
 their master's murdered.

60

[50]

It's gone—that ancient splendour
 no man could resist or fight,
 no man could overcome.
 Its glory rang in every ear,
 echoed in every heart.
 Now it's been thrown away.
 But each man feels the fear.
 For now, in all men's eyes,
 success is worshipped,
 more so than god himself.
 But Justice is vigilant—
 she tips the scales.
 With some she's quick,
 striking by light of day,
 for others sorrows wait,
 delaying until their lives
 are half way sunk in twilight,
 while others are embraced
 by night that never ends.

70

[60]

80

The nurturing earth drinks blood,
 she drinks her fill. That gore,
 which cries out for revenge,
 will not dissolve or seep away.
 The guilty live in utter desperation—
 madness preys upon their minds
 infecting them completely.
 The man who violates a virgin's bed
 cannot be redeemed. All rivers flow
 into one stream to cleanse his hand
 of black blood which defiles him.
 Such waters flow in vain.

90 [70]

As for me—gods set a fatal noose
 around my city, so I was led
 out of my father's house a slave.
 Now I do what I have to do—
 beat down my bitter rage.
 Against my inclinations,
 I follow what my masters say,
 whether right or wrong.
 Still, behind our veils
 we weep for her, this girl,
 her senseless suffering,
 as grief, concealed and cold,
 congeals our hearts to ice.

100

[80]

ELECTRA

You women who keep our house in order,
 now you're here attending me in prayers,
 in supplication, give me your advice.
 What should I say as I pour out these cups,
 my offering to grief? How frame my words
 to make my prayer a tribute to my father?
 Shall I say I bring these gifts with love,
 from doting wife to her beloved husband,
 from my mother? I have no strength for that.
 I don't know what to say, as I pour out
 this oil and honey on my father's tomb.
 Shall I recite the words men often use,
 "May those who send this noble tribute
 get back the same." No, let him give them
 a gift their treachery deserves! Or should I
 stand here in silence and dishonour, the way
 my father died, empty out these cups,
 with eyes averted as I toss the gift,
 let the earth drink, and then retrace my steps,
 like someone sent to carry out the trash
 left over from some purifying rite?
 Help me, my friends, with your advice.
 We share a common hatred in the house.
 Don't hide what's in your hearts. Don't be afraid
 of anyone. Fate waits for each of us—
 the free and those in bondage to another.
 Speak up, if you can think of something better.

110

[90]

120

130 [100]

CHORUS LEADER

I respect your father's tomb, as if it were
an altar. So I'll speak straight from my heart,
as you have asked.

ELECTRA

Then talk to me,
out of your reverence for my father's grave.

CHORUS LEADER

As you pour, bless those who are your friends. 140

ELECTRA

Of those close to me, whom shall I call friends? [110]

CHORUS LEADER

First, name yourself—then anyone
who hates Aegisthus.

ELECTRA

Then I'll make this prayer
on my own behalf. Shall I include you too?

CHORUS LEADER

That's your decision. In this ritual
you must let your judgment guide you.

ELECTRA

Who else should I then add to join with us?

CHORUS LEADER

He may be far from home, but don't forget Orestes.

ELECTRA

That's good. You give me excellent advice.

CHORUS LEADER

Remember, too, the guilty murderers. 150

ELECTRA

What do I say? I've never practised this.
Teach me what I should say.

CHORUS LEADER

Let some god
or mortal man come down on them.

ELECTRA

You mean as judge or as avenger? Which? [120]

CHORUS LEADER

Pronounce these words—and clearly—
“Someone who’ll pay back life by taking life.”

ELECTRA

Is it a righteous thing for me to do,
to petition gods like that?

CHORUS

Why not?
How can it not be a righteous thing to pray
to pay back one’s enemies for evil? 160

ELECTRA

O Hermes, mighty herald, moving
between earth above and earth below,
messenger to the dead, assist me now—
summon the spirits there beneath the ground
who guard my father’s house, to hear my prayers.
And call on Earth herself, who, giving birth
and nurturing all things, in due course takes back
the swollen tide of their increasing store.
As I pour out these offering to the dead,
I call upon my father, “Pity me— 170 [130]
and dear Orestes, too! How can we rule
in our own home? We’re beggars now,
as if our mother traded us away,
exchanged us for her mate, Aegisthus,
her partner in your murder. For now I live
just like a slave. Orestes lives in exile,
far from his estates. In their arrogance,
those two squander all the wealth you worked for.
And so I pray to you—dear father,
let good fortune bring Orestes home! 180
Father, hear me. Make me more self-controlled, [140]
than mother, my hand more righteous!
Those are my prayers for us. Our enemies—

for them, my father, I pray someone will come
 as your avenger, then kill your killers,
 in retribution, as is just. As I pray
 for our well being, I include this curse—
 may they be caught by their own evil.
 Bring us your blessing to the earth above,
 with help from gods, and Earth, and Justice,
 all combined to bring us victory.” 190

[Electra pours out her libation on the tomb.]

Those are my prayers, and over them I pour
 libations. Your duty now is to lament,
 to crown my prayers with flowers, chanting 150
 your mournful chorus for the dead.

CHORUS

Come, let our tears begin,
 fall, and die, as our master died.
 Let them guard us from evil,
 preserve the good, and keep away
 with our outpoured libations 200
 the polluting curse.
 Hear me, O hear me,
 my honoured master.
 May your disembodied spirit
 hear my prayer.

Alas, alas . . . ohhhhhhhh!
 Let him come now, 160
 some forceful man,
 a power with the spear.
 May he restore this house, 210
 bent Scythian bow in hand,
 a fist around his sword hilt.
 Like Ares, god of war,
 let him begin the slaughter!

ELECTRA

My father's now received his offerings.
 The earth has drunk them up. But look—
 here's something new. Come, look at it with me.

CHORUS

Speak up. My heart's afraid. It's dancing.

ELECTRA

I see a lock of hair, an offering . . . on the tomb.

CHORUS

Whose is it? A man's? A full-grown girl's?

220

ELECTRA

It shouldn't be too difficult to guess,
to sort out what this indicates.

[170]

CHORUS

How so? Let your youth instruct your elders.

ELECTRA

No one but me could have cut this off.

CHORUS

You're right. Those who should make offerings,
cutting their hair in grief, are enemies.

ELECTRA

Look at this . . . It looks just like . . .

CHORUS

Like whose?

I want to know.

ELECTRA

Like mine. It looks identical.

CHORUS

Perhaps Orestes? Did he place it here,
a secret offering?

ELECTRA

It really looks like his . . .
these curls . . .

230

CHORUS

But how could he come back?

ELECTRA

He sent it here, a token of respect [180]
for his dead father.

CHORUS

Those words of yours
give us fresh cause for tears, if there's no chance
Orestes will set foot in this land again.

ELECTRA

Over my heart, too, breaks a bitter wave.
I feel as if a sword had sliced right through me.
Seeing this hair, my eyes weep thirsty drops—
I can't hold back my flood of grief. There's no way
I would expect one of the citizens, 240
someone in Argos, to own this lock.
It's clearly not that murderess' hair,
my mother's—her treatment of her children [190]
profanes the very name of mother.
But how can I accept without a doubt
this offering's from the man I love the most,
Orestes? I'm just clinging to a hope.
Alas. If only, like a messenger,
this hair possessed a friendly human voice,
my thoughts would not be so distracted. 250
It would tell me clearly what to do.
If someone I detest had cut it off,
I'd throw this lock away, but if it's his,
my brother's, it could share my sorrow,
adorn this tomb, a tribute to my father. [200]
I call upon the gods who understand
how storms whirl us off course, like sailors.
But if we're fated to come safely home,
then mighty trees can spring from tiny seeds.

[Electra notices footprints in the dirt around the tomb.]

Here are some footprints—more evidence— 260
tracks of feet, just like my own—in pairs—
two sets of footprints, his own and others,
some companion's. The heels, the arches—
these prints are shaped just like my own . . . [210]

LIBATION BEARERS

[Electra traces the tracks from the tomb towards Orestes's hiding place. Orestes emerges to meet her as she follows the footprints.]

The pain of this . . . my mind grows dizzy . . .

ORESTES

Pray for what must still be done. Thank the gods
for answering your prayers. Pray to them
that all will work out well.

ELECTRA

What? The gods?

What have they given me?

ORESTES

You've come to see
the person you've been praying for all this time. 270

ELECTRA

Then you know the man I was calling for?

ORESTES

I know your sympathies are with Orestes.

ELECTRA

Yes, but how have my prayers been answered now?

ORESTES

I'm here. You need look no more for friends.
I'm the dearest one you have.

ELECTRA

No, stranger.

You're weaving a net, a trick to trap me. [220]

ORESTES

If so, I plot against myself as well.

ELECTRA

You just want to laugh at my distress.

ORESTES

If I laugh at you, I'm laughing at myself.

ELECTRA

Orestes . . . is it truly you? Can I
call you Orestes? 280

ORESTES

Yes, you can.
You're looking at Orestes in the flesh.
Why take so long to recognize the truth?
When you saw the lock of hair, that token
of my grief, and traced my footprints in the dust,
your imagination flew—you thought
you saw me. Look. Put this hair in place. [230]
It's your brother's. And it matches yours.
See this weaving here—that's your handiwork.
You worked the loom. Look at this design, 290
these animals . . .

[Electra is finally convinced. She almost breaks down with joy]

Control yourself. Calm down.
Don't get too overjoyed. Remember this—
our closest family is our enemy.

ELECTRA

You dearest member of your father's house.
the seed of hope through all our weeping—
trust to your own strength and win back again
your father's home. How my eyes rejoice!
To me you are four different loves—fate
declares that I must call you father,
and on you falls the love I ought to feel 300 [240]
towards my mother, who's earned my hate.
Then there's the love I bore my sister,
Iphigeneia, that cruel sacrifice—
and you're my faithful brother. You alone
sustained my sense of honour. May Power
and Justice stand with us now, our allies—
and may almighty Zeus make up the third.

ORESTES

O Zeus, Zeus, look down on what we do!
See the abandoned fledglings of the eagle,
whose father perished in the viper's coils, 310
that deadly net. Orphans now, we bear

the pangs of hunger, not yet mature enough [250]
 to bring our father's quarry to the nest.
 See us like this—I mean me and Electra—
 children without a father, both outcasts,
 banished from our home. If you wipe out
 these fledglings, what respect will you receive
 at feasts from hands like his, their father's,
 who offered you such wealthy sacrifice?
 Kill off the eagle's brood, then who will trust 320
 the signs you send? If this royal stock decays, [260]
 it cannot consecrate your altars
 with sacrificial oxen in the morning.
 Stand by us. You can elevate our house
 from its debased condition, make it great,
 though now it seems completely ruined.

CHORUS LEADER

Children, saviours of your father's home,
 don't speak too loud. Someone may hear you,
 my children, and to hear his tongue run on
 report to those in charge. O how I wish 330
 I see them dead one day, roasting in flames,
 sizzling like pitch.

ORESTES

Apollo's great oracle
 surely will defend me. Its orders were
 that I should undertake this danger. [270]
 It cried out in prophecy, foretelling
 many winters of calamity would chill
 my hot heart, if I did not take revenge
 on those who killed my father. It ordered me
 to murder them the way they murdered him,
 insisting they could not pay the penalty 340
 with their possessions. The oracle declared,
 "If not, you'll pay the debt with your own life,
 a life of troubles." It spoke a revelation,
 making known to men the wrath of blood guilt—
 from underneath the earth, infectious plagues,
 leprous sores which gnaw the flesh, fangs chewing [280]
 living tissue, festering white rot in the sores.
 It mentioned other miseries as well—
 attacks by vengeful Furies, stemming
 from a slaughtered father's blood, dark bolts 350

from gods below, aroused by murdered kinsmen
 calling for revenge, frenzied night fits.³
 Such terrors plague the man—he sees them all
 so clearly, eyeballs rolling in the dark.
 Then he's chased in exile from the city,
 his body scourged by bronze-tipped whips. [290]
 A man like this can never share the wine bowl,
 no libations mixed with love. We don't see
 his father's anger, but it casts him out—
 no access to an altar. There's no relief, 360
 and no one takes him in, until at last,
 universally despised, without a friend,
 he wastes in all-consuming pain and dies.
 Am I not right to trust such oracles?
 Even if I don't, the work must still be done.
 Many feelings lead to one conclusion—
 the gods' decree, my keen paternal grief, [300]
 the weight of poverty I bear. Besides,
 my countrymen, most glorious of men,
 whose courageous spirit brought down Troy, 370
 should not be subject to a pair of women.
 For Aegisthus is at heart a woman—
 if not, we'll learn about it soon enough.

CHORUS

O mighty Fates, bring all this to pass.
 Through Zeus's power, make all things right.
 For Justice, as she turns the scales
 exacting retribution, cries aloud,
 "Hostile words for hostile words— [310]
 let it be done. One murderous stroke
 is paid off by another lethal blow. 380
 The one who acts must suffer."
 So runs the ancient saying,
 now three generations old.

ORESTES

O my unhappy father,
 what can I say for you or do,
 to send you, where you rest
 so far away, some light
 to drive away your darkness?

³The Furies are the goddesses of blood revenge, particularly within the family.

But nonetheless some joy [320]
 comes from a funeral lament 390
 for glorious sons of Atreus,
 who once possessed the house.⁴

CHORUS

My child, among the dead
 the savage jaws of fire
 cannot destroy the spirit.
 He'll show his rage in time.
 Dead men receive their dirge—
 the guilty stand revealed.
 A father's funeral lament,
 strong and clear and just, 400
 searches far and wide, [330]
 confounding those who killed.

ELECTRA

Hear us now, my father,
 as, in turn, we mourn and weep.
 Your two children at your tomb
 now sing your death song.
 Your tomb has welcomed us,
 two suppliants and outcasts.
 What in this is good?
 What free from trouble? 410
 Who wrestles death and wins?

CHORUS

But if god wills it, he can turn [340]
 our dirges into joyful songs—
 instead of funeral laments
 around this monument
 chants of triumph ringing out
 throughout the palace halls,
 a welcome celebration
 for reunion with a friend.

ORESTES

My father, if only you had died 420
 hit by some Lycian spear at Troy!
 You'd have left your glory

⁴Atreus was the father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

with your children in their home.
 In their dealings with the world
 men would now honour them. [350]
 You'd have won a tomb raised high
 in lands across the seas, a death
 your home could bear with ease.

CHORUS

Dear to the men you loved,
 the ones who died so bravely, 430
 you'd stand out under earth,
 as a majestic lord, minister
 of the mightiest gods below,
 who rule the dead. In life,
 you were a king of men— [360]
 the ones who hold the staff
 that every man obeys,
 those with authority
 to sentence men to die.

ELECTRA

I don't want you dead, my father, 440
 not even under Trojan walls,
 with all those other men
 who perished by the spear,
 where the Scamander flows.⁵
 No. I'd much prefer
 your killers had been killed
 by their own families,
 just as they murdered you.
 People then in far-off lands
 would hear about their deaths 450 [370]
 and not our present trouble.

CHORUS

Children, these things you say
 are merely your desires,
 finer than gold, greater still
 than the great happiness
 of those who live in bliss
 beyond the northern wind.
 But wishing is an easy thing.

⁵The Scamander was the river near Troy, the site of many battles in the Trojan War.

Still, now it's striking home,
 that double whip—for now
 460 protectors underneath the earth
 are helping us. Our masters
 are unholy creatures
 with polluted hands.
 The children win the day!

ORESTES

Our words, like arrows, [380]
 pierce down into the earth
 straight to my father's ear.
 O Zeus, Zeus, send us
 from the world below 470
 your long-delayed revenge,
 pay back the wickedness
 brought on by human hands.
 O let that come to pass—
 and thus avenge all fathers.

CHORUS

Let my heart cry out in triumph
 when that man is stabbed,
 when that woman dies.
 Why should my spirit hide
 what hovers here before me, 480
 when driving hatred, like a storm, [390]
 a biting headwind,
 breaks across my heart?

ELECTRA

O when will mighty Zeus
 strike them with his fist—
 split their skulls apart!
 Alas, alas! Give our land
 some sign—confirm our faith.
 From these crimes I seek
 the rights of justice. 490
 O Earth, hear me, and you,
 blessed gods in earth below.

CHORUS

It's the law—once drops of blood [400]
 are shed upon the ground

they cry out for still more blood.
 Slaughter calls upon the Furies
 of those who have been killed.
 Thus, hard on murder's heels
 destruction comes again.

ORESTES

Lords of the world below, alas, 500
 see the mighty curses of the dead.
 See survivors of the line of Atreus,
 here in our helplessness,
 cast out from home, dishonoured.
 O Zeus, where can we turn?

CHORUS

My fond heart races once again [410]
 to hear your pitiful lament.
 But as I listen to your words
 I lose my hope. My heart
 grows dark. But then again 510
 hope comes to make me strong—
 all my unhappiness is gone.
 I see a bright new dawn.

ELECTRA

To what can we appeal? What else
 but to the agonies we suffer,
 anguish from the one who bore us,
 our mother. So let her grovel. [420]
 She'll not appease our pain.
 We're bred from her, like wolves,
 whose savage hearts do not relent. 520

CHORUS

Like some Asian wailing woman,
 I beat out my lament, my fists
 keep pounding out the blows
 in quick succession. You see
 my hands—I stretch them out,
 then strike down from above.
 My torment beats upon my head
 until it breaks for sorrow.

ELECTRA

O cruel and reckless mother,
 that savage burial, our king, [430]
 no fellow citizens around, 530
 no suffering procession—
 you dared place him in the tomb
 without the rites of mourning.

ORESTES

Alas! As you say, totally disgraced.
 But she'll pay for his dishonour,
 by the gods, by my own hands.
 Let me kill her. Then let me die.

CHORUS

And let me tell you this—
 she first hacked off his limbs, 540 [440]
 then hung them round his neck.
 That's how she buried him,
 to make that slaughter
 a burden on your life—
 a thing you could not bear.
 You hear me? Your father's death—
 she made it an abomination.

ELECTRA

You describe my father's death,
 but I too was utterly disgraced,
 worth nothing, set apart, 550
 inside a cell, as if I were
 some rabid dog. I wept.
 What had I to laugh about,
 as I shed all those tears in hiding?
 Hear that. Carve that on your heart. [450]

CHORUS

Let your ears pick up her story,
 but keep your spirit firm.
 Things now stand as they stand.
 You're keen to know what's next,
 but you must wait, prepared 570
 to fight on with no turning back.

ORESTES

Father, I call on you. Stand by your children.

ELECTRA

Through these tears I join his call.

CHORUS

In unison, our voices blend as one—
hear us. Return into the light.
Join us against our enemies.

[460]

ORESTES

Now war god Ares goes to meet
the war god Ares. Right fights with right.

ELECTRA

Dear gods, let justice choose what's right.

CHORUS

I hear these prayers and shudder.
This doom's been long delayed,
but it does come for those who pray.

580

O family bred for torments,
for the bloody strokes
of harsh discordant ruin,
for pains beyond enduring,
grief that can't be staunched.
For all this evil there's a remedy,
not from some stranger,
someone outside the house,
but from within, the cure
that blood strife brings,
their savage bloody fight.
To gods beneath the ground
we sing this hymn.

[470]

590

Hear us, you blessed gods of earth,
hear this supplication, and assist
with your good will these children.
Give them the victory!

ORESTES

Father, you may not have perished like a king,

600

but, in answer to my prayer, make me
the master of your house.

[480]

ELECTRA

I, too, father,
have a request of you—let me escape,
once I've accomplished this enormous task,
once Aegisthus is destroyed.

ORESTES

Yes.
Then men would set up on your behalf
those feasts of honour our laws demand.
But otherwise, when people sacrifice
burnt offering to Earth at solemn banquets
they will not honour you.

ELECTRA

And I, too,
at my marriage feast, from the full store
of what I inherit in my father's house,
will pour libations to you. And your tomb
I'll honour above all other shrines.

610

ORESTES

O Earth, send my father up to see our fight.

ELECTRA

O Persephone, grant us glorious power.⁶

[490]

ORESTES

My father, remember that bath
where you were slaughtered.

ELECTRA

Remember the net in which they killed you.

ORESTES

My father, you were trapped in fetters,
but they weren't forged in bronze.

620

⁶Persephone is the queen of the underworld, wife of Hades.

ELECTRA

They covered you
with their deceit and shame.

ORESTES

Father, these taunts—
do they not stir your spirit?

ELECTRA

Will you raise
that beloved head of yours upright?

ORESTES

Either send Justice here to stand with us,
the ones you love, or let us, in our turn,
catch them in our grip, as they caught you—
that is, if you want to beat them down,
after the way they overpowered you.

ELECTRA

Father, listen to my last appeal—
see your children huddled at your tomb.
Take pity on them, your son and daughter.

630 [500]

ORESTES

Don't let the seed of Pelops disappear.⁷
With us alive, in death you cannot die.

ELECTRA

For to a man that's dead his children
are saving testament—like corks,
they hold up the net and keep the mesh
from sinking deep into the sea.

ORESTES

Hear us!
We're making our lament on your behalf.
Honour our request and save yourself.

640

CHORUS LEADER

There's nothing wrong expanding your lament.
For that will honour this neglected tomb.

[510]

⁷Pelops was the original founder of the royal family of Argos.

But since your heart is rightly set to act,
it's time to test your fortune, time to start.

ORESTES

You're right. But first we might ask this question:
Why did that woman send out these libations?
What did she have in mind, trying so late
to heal a crime which cannot be forgiven?
What she sent here was paltry tribute
to the unforgiving dead. I don't see
what she intends. The gift's too trivial
for her offence. As the old saying runs,
"Pour out all you've got to make amends
for bloodshed, your work is all in vain."
If you know her reason, tell me now.
I'd like to hear.

650

[520]

CHORUS LEADER

My child, I know—I was there.
She had bad dreams. Vague terrors in the night
upset her. So that godless woman sent these gifts.

ORESTES

Do you know the nature of her dreams?
Can you give me details?

CHORUS LEADER

She'd given birth,
but to a snake. That's what she told me.

660

ORESTES

How did the dream end up? What happened?

CHORUS LEADER

She set it in bed wrapped in swaddling clothes,
just like a child.

ORESTES

And that newborn snake,
what did it want for nourishment?

[530]

CHORUS LEADER

She dreamt she offered it her breasts.

ORESTES

Didn't the monster bite her nipple?

CHORUS LEADER

No. But with her milk it sucked out clots of blood.

ORESTES

It's an omen. Her vision means a man.

CHORUS LEADER

She woke up with a scream, quite terrified. 670
Many torches which stay unlit at night
were set ablaze throughout the house
to calm our mistress. Then she sent out
libations for the dead—in the hope
they'd work like medicine for her distress.

ORESTES

I pray to Earth and to my father's tomb [540]
that this dream will fulfill itself in me.
I think it matches me in every point.
If that snake came from the same womb as me,
if it was wrapped up in my swaddling clothes 680
and opened up its jaws to suck the milk
that nourished me, mixing sweet milk with blood,
so she cried out in terror at the sight,
then that must mean she'll die by violence,
from nursing such a violent beast.
I am that snake. And I will kill her. [550]
That's the meaning of this dream.

CHORUS LEADER

Your reading of her dream seems right to me.
So let it come. Tell your friends the rest—
what they must do or take care not to do. 690

ORESTES

My plan is simple. First, Electra here
must go inside. I'm instructing her
to keep this bond with me a secret.
The two in there deceived a noble man,
then killed him. So we'll use deceit on them.
They'll die in the same net. Lord Apollo,
who's never wrong in what he prophesies,

has ordered this. I'll approach the outer gates, [560]
 pretending I'm a stranger, prepared
 for anything. Pylades goes with me, 700
 as guest and ally of the house. We two
 will speak Parnassian dialect of Phocis.
 If no one at the gate is in the mood
 to let us in, alleging that the house
 is haunted by some evil demon,
 we'll wait there, so any passer-by
 will be intrigued and say, "What's going on?
 Why does Aegisthus shut his doors like this [570]
 against a suppliant? Is he at home?
 Is he aware of this?" If I get past the gate, 710
 across the outer threshold, then find that man
 seated on my father's throne or meet him
 face to face, his eyes will shift and fall,
 I promise you. Before he's had time to ask,
 "Stranger, what country are you from?"
 I'll kill him quickly with my sword.
 Our Fury never lacked for blood—
 for her third draught she'll drink his pure.
 Now, Electra, keep a close watch in there,
 check what's going on inside the house. 720
 We'll need to work on this together. [580]
 You women, be careful what you say—
 keep quiet—speak only when you have to.
 As for the rest, I invoke Apollo
 to cast his eyes down here and be my guide
 when the time comes to fight it out with swords.

[Orestes, Pylades, and Electra leave together.]

CHORUS

Earth brings forth many horrors—
 terrors and agonies—the sea's arms
 hold monsters, savage beasts.
 Between the earth and heaven 730
 hang fiery lights, suspended high. [590]
 Winged birds and beasts
 that walk along the ground
 can also speak of storms,
 the whirlwind's power.
 But who of us can speak
 about the arrogance of men

or women's reckless passion
 beyond all self-control,
 so they become conspirators 740
 in all our lethal woes?
 Passionate desire wins out—
 it gains a fatal victory
 in every woman.
 It ends all married love [600]
 in men and beasts.
 A man with any sense
 should recognize these things,
 once he recalls Althaea,
 ruthless child of Thestius, 750
 who planned her own son's ruin.
 She burned the fatal torch,
 knowing that Meleager's life,
 from the time he first appeared
 howling from his mother's womb,
 depended on that wood.⁸
 And so it was—he stayed alive [610]
 until her fire doomed him.
 Another story of a hateful girl
 tells of that murderous Scylla, 760
 who killed her father,
 brought to it by his enemies.
 Tempted by a gift from Minos,
 a golden necklace made in Crete,
 she plucked out her father's hair,
 the one which made Nisus immortal.
 As he lay peacefully asleep, [620]
 then died, murdered by that bitch,
 and Hermes led him off.⁹
 As I recall these stories 770
 of savagery without remorse,
 it's time to speak of marriages
 in which there was no love,
 which laid a curse upon the house,

⁸Althaea was the mother of Meleager. When he was born, the Fates told her that Meleager would live as long as a log in the fireplace. Althaea removed the log and preserved it to keep Meleager alive. However, when Meleager, in an angry fit, killed Althaea's two brothers, she threw the log in the fire and killed her son.

⁹Nisus had a purple lock of hair on which the safety of his kingdom depended. When Minos, king of Crete, besieged their city, Scylla, daughter of the king, cut off her father's lock and presented it to Minos, who promptly abandoned her.

schemes devised by woman's cunning
 against her warrior lord, a man
 his enemies have cause to honour.
 I value hearth and home
 where passions do not rule,
 where women's spirits 780
 rein in their waywardness. [630]
 Of all such tales of crime, the worst
 concerns the isle of Lemnos,
 where all the women killed their men.¹⁰
 At that story people moan—
 they weep for that abomination.
 When some new troubles come
 men measure them by Lemnos.
 Horror at that deed brought on
 the hatred of the gods, and thus, 790
 cast out by humankind and in disgrace,
 that women's race dies out.
 No man can hold in reverence
 what gods abhor. So of these tales
 which one can I not justly cite?
 Justice wields her sword.
 She thrusts it home—
 hungry and sharp, [640]
 it slices deep,
 right by the lungs— 800
 and so the lawlessness
 of those who flout what's right,
 who violate the majesty of Zeus,
 lies trampled underfoot.
 The anvil of Justice now holds firm.
 Fate hammers out her sword—
 she forges it in time.
 At last the brooding Fury comes,
 famous spirit of revenge—
 leading a child inside the house, 810
 to cleanse the stain of blood, [650]
 the family curse from long ago.

[Enter Orestes and Pylades, with a couple of attendants. They move up to the front doors of the royal palace. Orestes knocks loudly on the door]

¹⁰The women of Lemnos offended the goddess Aphrodite, who, in revenge gave them all a dreadful smell. When the men of Lemnos started sleeping with other women, the wives on the island killed their husbands.

ORESTES

Hey, in there! You hear this knocking on the door?
 I'll try again. Anyone in there?
 All right, a third attempt. I'm knocking here—
 are you coming out? Anyone in there?
 Hello! Does Aegisthus welcome strangers?

SERVANT [*from within*]

All right. All right. I hear you. Stranger,
 what country are you from? Who are you?

ORESTES

Announce me to the masters of the house. 820
 I've come to bring them news. And hurry! [660]
 Night's black chariot is speeding overhead.
 It's time for people on the road to rest—
 drop anchor where all strangers feel at home.
 Tell someone to come out who's in control—
 the mistress would be fine, the master
 even better. We could speak our minds.
 After all, politeness can obscure the sense.
 When we talk man to man, we get the point—
 we say just what we mean without reserve. 830

[Clytaemnestra and Electra enter through the palace doors]

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Stranger, welcome. Just ask for what you need.
 Inside we have all luxuries of home—
 warm baths and beds to charm away your pains. [670]
 We live under the eyes of Justice here.
 But if your business is more serious,
 men's work, then we'll send for Aegisthus.

ORESTES

I'm a stranger—a Daulian from Phocis—
 coming to Argos on private business,
 carrying this pack. I need to pause and rest.
 On my way here I ran into a man— 840
 we'd never met before. He told me
 where he was going and asked my route.
 As we talked, I learned his name—Strophius.
 He came from Phocis, too. And he said this,
 "Well, friend, since you're heading off to Argos, [680]

here's a message for Orestes' parents,
 something they've a right to know, so please
 remember it: Orestes is dead. Don't forget.
 Then, when you return, you can tell me
 whether his family wants to bring him back 850
 or have him buried here in Phocis,
 where he's a stranger, forever outcast.
 Right now his ashes sit in a bronze urn.
 The man was truly mourned." That's my message.
 That's what I heard. At this point I'm not sure
 whether I'm telling this to anyone who cares,
 but Orestes' parent ought to be informed. [690]

CLYTAEMNESTRA

I . . . this news . . . what you just said . . .
 it's shattering . . . that curse we can't repress.
 It haunts the house, ranges everywhere . . . 860
 Someone kept safe and far away from here
 the curse seeks out. Its arrow strikes and kills.
 It takes those I love, drives me to desperation.
 And now Orestes. He was well prepared.
 He kept his feet well clear of muddy ground
 where hidden danger lurks. He offered hope
 the Furies' striking revels in this house
 might find a cure. Now, from what you say,
 we've lost that hope.

ORESTES

As far as I'm concerned, [700]
 with hosts as prosperous as you, I wish 870
 you'd seen me as the bearer of good news
 and welcomed me for that. What's kinder
 than the link between a stranger and his host?
 But to my mind, it would have been profane
 if I'd not told his loved ones, as I promised,
 as hospitality demands.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Don't worry.
 You'll receive what you deserve. In this house
 you're no less welcome for your news,
 which, in any case, someone else would bring.
 But now's the time when strangers on the road 880 [710]
 get entertained once their long journey's done.

[Clytaemnestra turns to Electra, ordering her as if she were a servant]

You there—take this traveller to the rooms
 we use to entertain our guests—and with him
 these fellow travellers, his attendants.
 Look after them the way this house requires.
 Those are my orders. See you follow them.
 I'm holding you responsible. Meanwhile,
 I'll go find the master of the house,
 tell him the news. We don't lack friends—
 from them we'll seek advice about this death. 890

[Electra escorts Orestes, Pylades, and their attendants into the palace. Clytaemnestra enters the palace. The Chorus is left alone on stage.]

CHORUS LEADER

Dear fellow slaves who serve this house,
 how long before our words can demonstrate
 just how strongly we support Orestes? [720]

CHORUS

O sacred Earth,
 heaped-up burial mound,
 lying above that noble corpse,
 commander of the ships,
 hear me now,
 help me now.
 Now's the moment 900
 for Persuasion to come in
 with her deceit,
 for that stealthy god,
 Hermes of the lower world,
 to guide the fight,
 the fatal clash of swords.

[Enter Orestes's Nurse, Cilissa, in tears.]

CHORUS LEADER

It seems the stranger's mischief is at work. [730]
 Here comes Orestes' nurse. I see she's crying.
 Cilissa, why are you walking by the gates,
 with your unpaid companion Sorrow? 910

NURSE

My mistress ordered me to fetch Aegisthus
 to meet the strangers—and to hurry up—
 so he can find out clearly, man to man,
 the news that's just arrived. With servants
 she puts on her gloomy face, but deep down
 her eyes are laughing at how well all this
 has ended up for her. But for this house [740]
 the stranger's news is simply a disaster.
 Once Aegisthus hears, gets the full report,
 he'll jump for joy. How miserable I feel! 920
 The old troubles of the house of Atreus,
 so hard to bear, how they've hurt my heart.
 I get these chest pains. But a blow like this—
 I've never had to bear such sorrow.
 Other troubles I've endured with patience,
 but dear Orestes, how it breaks my heart!
 When he was born, I got him from his mother. [750]
 I nursed him. I spent all night on my feet,
 answering his cries. So much tiring work—
 all for nothing. A helpless child like that 930
 one has to nurse as if he were a beast.
 How'd I do that? By following his moods.
 A child in swaddling clothes can't speak at all.
 So if he needed something to eat or drink,
 or had just wet himself, his one response
 came from his instincts. So I had to use
 a prophet's skill. But often I was wrong.
 I had to launder linen. Yes, I was
 wet nurse and washerwoman, all in one, [760]
 two special skills. I received Orestes 940
 from his own father's hands. Now he's dead.
 That's what I've been told. It makes me cry.
 Well, I must go. I have to fetch Aegisthus,
 the man who brought this house to ruin.
 He'll be glad enough to hear my words.

CHORUS LEADER

Did she tell him how to come and what to bring?

NURSE

How's that? Say it again. I need a clearer sense
 of what you're asking.

CHORUS LEADER

Did she tell him
to come with guards or unattended?

NURSE

She said he should bring his spearmen with him. 950

CHORUS LEADER

Don't give that message to Aegisthus, [770]
that hateful tyrant. Tell him to come alone,
with a joyous heart, as quickly as he can.
He won't suspect a thing. The messenger
can straighten out a crooked message.

NURSE

What? Does your heart feel good about this news?

CHORUS LEADER

Why not, if Zeus turns evil into good?

NURSE

How's that to happen? Orestes,
the house's hope, is gone.

CHORUS LEADER

Not so fast.
A prophet who claimed that would be a bad one. 960

NURSE

What are you saying? Do you know something
more than what I've heard?

CHORUS LEADER

Go on then.
Relay your message. Do what you've been told.
Let the gods care about what most concerns them. [780]

NURSE

All right, I'll go and do what you suggest.
With blessings from the gods, I pray all this
will work out for the best.

[Exit Nurse, off in search of Aegisthus, who is not in the palace.]

CHORUS

Now, in answer to my prayers,
 I implore you, Zeus,
 father of Olympian gods, 970
 restore this house,
 give it good fortune, so those
 who rightly love due order
 may witness it right here.
 In every word we cry,
 we plead for justice.
 O Zeus, protect what's right.

Zeus, Zeus,
 inside that palace [790]
 place him face to face 980
 before his enemies.
 If you exalt him
 he'll willingly repay you,
 three or four times over.

You know that orphan colt,
 child of a man you cherish,
 stands now in harness,
 yoked to a chariot of pain.
 Control the way he runs,
 preserve his pace, 990
 so he will last the course,
 and we may see him surge,
 as he races to his goal.

You gods inside the house, [800]
 in those inner chambers,
 where you celebrate its wealth,
 hear me, you gods
 who sympathize with us.
 Cleanse that ancient blood
 of crimes committed long ago. 1000
 Let old murder cease to breed.

And Apollo, you who dwell
 in that massive well-built cavern,
 grant that this man's house
 may raise its head once more,
 so with loving eyes we see

the veil of darkness yield
to freedom's light. [810]

May Hermes, Maia's son,
support him in what's right. 1010
He sends the finest winds
to hold an enterprise on course,
when that's his will—
and when he so desires,
he will make known
much hidden from our view,
or speak in riddles in the night,
darkening men's eyes,
which see no better by the light of day.

Soon at last we'll shout in song 1020
of the deliverance of this house— [820]
no shrill lament of those who mourn,
but robust songs the sea wives sing
when the wind sits fair,
"Good sailing now—for me,
for me this means more riches—
no dangers for the ones I love."

But you, Orestes, do your part—
when your moment comes, be brave.
When she cries out "My son!" 1030
cry in return "My father's son!"
Then murder her in innocence. [830]
In your heart maintain
the heart of Perseus.¹¹
Satisfy the rage
of those you love
under the earth,
and here above.
With blood murder
inside the house 1040
eradicate the cause
of all our blood-guilt.

[Enter Aegisthus.]

¹¹Perseus, a son of Zeus, was a famous hero, who, among other things, killed the Gorgon Medusa, whose gaze turned people to stone.

AEGISTHUS

A stranger's story called me here—
 I'm told that travellers have arrived
 with startling and unwelcome news— [840]
 Orestes is dead—yet one more burden
 laid upon this house, a terrifying load,
 while it still bears raw festering wounds
 from earlier murder. But is what they saw
 the living truth? That's what I must confirm. 1050
 Or is it some fearful women's gossip,
 which blazes up, then dies away to nothing?
 Can you clear my mind? What do you know?

CHORUS LEADER

Well, we heard the news. But go inside.
 You can learn it from the guests themselves.
 The power in a messenger's report
 is not like hearing what he has to say
 when you confront him face to face. [850]

AEGISTHUS

I want to see this messenger and check
 if he was present at Orestes' death, 1060
 or if he's just repeating what he heard
 from some vague rumours. I'll see through him.
 These keen eyes of mine won't be deceived.

[Exit Aegisthus into the palace.]

CHORUS

Zeus, O Zeus,
 what do I say? How do I start
 appealing to the gods in prayer?
 How from a loyal heart
 can I find what to say,
 matching words with deeds?
 Now blood-stained blades 1070
 are slicing men to death [860]
 and totally destroying forever
 Agamemnon's house, or else
 with freedom's blazing light
 Orestes wins the throne,
 and all his father's riches.
 The ambush now is set—

noble Orestes by himself
must face two enemies.
Let him emerge the victor!

1080

[Aegisthus screams in pain from inside the palace.]

CHORUS MEMBERS *[speaking separately]*

Listen!

[870]

What was that?

What's going on,
in there, inside the palace?

[Some members of the chorus start to move towards the palace doors.]

CHORUS LEADER

Stay back. Until this work is finished,
we won't get involved in all the bloodshed.
That way no one can blame us.

[A servant emerges through the palace doors.]

It's over.

Whatever the result, the fighting's over.

SERVANT

O it's horrible—my master's killed!
He's dead. Alas! I'll cry it out again,
a third time, Aegisthus is no more!

[The servant moves to a side door and tries desperately to pull it open.]

Come on! Come on! Open this door! Hurry!
Unbolt the women's doors! A strong right arm
is all it takes! Not to help Aegisthus—
he's already dead. No point in trying.
Come on! Am I shouting to the deaf,
or are you all asleep?

1090

[880]

[The servant gives up pounding on the side door.]

A waste of time.

Where's Clytaemnestra gone? What's she doing?
Her own neck's resting on the razor's edge—
this justice could strike her down as well.

[Enter Clytaemnestra through the main palace doors.]

CLYTAEMNESTRA

What's happening? Why are you shouting
all around the house?

SERVANT

I'm telling you
the dead are murdering the living! 1100

CLYTAEMNESTRA

I see. I understand your paradox.
We're being destroyed by someone's trickery,
just as we destroyed. All right, then,
get me a man-killing axe—and quickly!

[Exit servant into the palace.]

Let's see now if we win through or lose. [890]
The wretched business brings me down to this.

[The palace doors open to reveal the dead body of Aegisthus with Orestes standing over it. Pylades is beside Orestes.]

ORESTES

The very one I seek. This fellow here
has had enough.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

No, not Aegisthus,
not my love, my power . . . dead. 1110

ORESTES

You loved this man? Then you'll find your rest
in a common grave with him—he's one man
you won't abandon when he dies.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Hold off, my son, my child. Take pity
on these breasts. Here you often lay asleep.
Your toothless gums sucked out the milk
that made you strong.

ORESTES

Pylades, what do I do?
It's a dreadful act to kill my mother.

PYLADES

What then becomes of what Apollo said, [900]
what he foretold at Delphi? We made an oath. 1120
Make all men your enemies but not the gods.

ORESTES

That's good advice. As judge in this debate
I say you prevail.

[Orestes turns on Clytaemnestra and pulls her towards the body of Aegisthus.]

Over here.
I want to kill you right beside this man.
When he was alive, you considered him
better than my father, so once you're dead
you can sleep on by his side. You loved him.
The man you should have loved you hated.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

I brought you up. Let me grow old with you.

ORESTES

What? Kill my father and then live with me? 1130

CLYTAEMNESTRA

My child, in this our fate's to blame. [910]

ORESTES

Then, in the same way, Fate brings on your death.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

My son, do you not fear your mother's curse?

ORESTES

You bore me, then threw me out to misery.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

No, no—I sent you to live with a friend.

ORESTES

You sold me in disgrace—a free man's son.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

What's the price I charged for you?

ORESTES

That's too shameful to declare in public.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Don't forget to name your father's failings, too.

ORESTES

Don't charge him with anything—he worked hard
while you sat here at home. 1140

CLYTAEMNESTRA

My son, it's painful
for women to go on without their men. [920]

ORESTES

Maybe, but while they stay safely in the home
their men look after them.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

My son, you really mean to do this—
to slaughter your own mother?

ORESTES

You kill yourself.
I'll not be the murderer. You will.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Take care.
The vicious hounds which avenge all mothers
will hunt you down.

ORESTES

What about my father's?
If I don't kill you, there's no escaping them.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

It seems as if, while still alive, I waste
my useless tears at my own tomb. 1150

ORESTES

My father's destiny has marked you out.
It states that you must die.

CLYTAEMNESTRA

Alas for me!
You are the snake I bore and nourished.

ORESTES

Yes. That terror in your dream foretold the truth.
You killed the man you should not kill, and now [930]
you'll suffer what no one should ever see.

[Orestes pushes Clytaemnestra inside the palace doors. Pylades goes with them. The doors close behind them.]

CHORUS LEADER

The fate of these two victims makes me grieve.
But long-suffering Orestes rides the crest
of so much bloodshed, we'd prefer he triumph— 1160
the bright eyes of this house must never fade.

CHORUS

Just as justice came at last
to Priam and his sons,
a crushing retribution,
so a double lion comes
to Agamemnon's house,
a two-fold slaughter.¹²
Apollo's suppliant, the exile, [940]
sees his action through,
driven on by justice 1170
sent from gods above.

Raise now a shout of triumph
above our master's house,
free of misery at last,
free of that tainted couple
squandering its wealth,
and free of its unhappy fate.

¹²Priam was king of Troy, killed when the city was ransacked at the end of the Trojan War.

He came back with a secret plan,
 fighting to win crafty vengeance.
 The goddess took him by the hand, 1180
 true daughter of great Zeus,
 his guide throughout the fight. [950]
 Men call her rightful Justice—
 who destroys her enemies
 once she breathes in anger.

Raise a shout of triumph now
 above our master's house,
 free of misery at last,
 free of that tainted couple
 squandering its wealth, 1190
 free of its unhappy destiny.

From his shrine deep within the earth,
 Parnassian Apollo spoke in prophecy—
 "Well intentioned stealthy trickery
 will conquer long-entrenched deceit."
 I pray his words somehow prevail,
 so I never am a slave to wickedness.
 True reverence should worship heaven's rule. [960]

Look now, dawn is coming!
 Great chains on the home are falling off. 1200
 Let this house rise up! For far too long
 it's lain in pieces on the ground.

Time, which brings all things to pass,
 will soon move through these doors,
 once purifying rites expel
 polluting evil. That will change
 the roll of fortune's dice—they'll fall
 so all can see the fair result,
 a happy destiny once more [970]
 for all who live within the house. 1210

Look now, dawn is coming!
 Great chains on the home are falling off.
 Let this house rise up! For far too long
 it's lain in pieces on the ground.

[The palace doors are thrown open, revealing Orestes standing above the bodies of Aegisthus and Clytaemnestra. Pylades stands beside Orestes. With them are attendants holding the bloodstained robes of Agamemnon.]

ORESTES

Here you see them—this pair of tyrants.
 They killed my father, then robbed my home.
 Once they sat enthroned in regal splendour.
 They're lovers still, as you can witness here
 by how they died, true to the oaths they swore.
 They made a pact to murder my poor father, 1220
 then die together. Well, they've kept their word.

[Orestes starts unfurling the robes in which Agamemnon was killed.]

Look at this again, all those of you [980]
 who pay attention to this house's troubles.
 This robe they used to trap my helpless father.
 With it they tied his hands and lashed his feet.
 Spread it out. Stand round here in a group—
 put it on display, my father's death shroud,
 so that the Father (not mine—the one
 who sees everything, the Sun) can see
 my mother's sacrilege. Then he will come 1230
 on the day when I am judged, to testify
 that I pursued and even killed my mother
 in a just cause. About Aegisthus' death
 there's nothing I need say. As an adulterer, [990]
 he dies—our law's just punishment.
 But as for her who planned this evil act
 against her husband, a man whose children
 she carried in her womb—I loved her once,
 but she became my bitter enemy,
 as you can see. What do you make of her? 1240
 If she'd been born a viper or sea snake,
 she wouldn't need to bite—her very touch
 would make men rot, so evil is her heart,
 so reckless.

[Orestes stoops and picks up the bloody robe.]

What do I call this?
 What fine words will do? A snare for some wild beast?
 A corpse's shroud? The curtain from a bath

wrapped round his legs? No. It's a hunting net.
 That name sounds right—robes to trap a man,
 entangling his feet, something a highway thief
 might use to trick and rob a stranger.
 With such a net he'd take so many lives,
 his pleasure in the work would warm his heart.
 May I never live with such a woman.
 Before that, let the gods destroy me—
 let me die without a child.

[1000]

1250

CHORUS

Alas for this horrific act,
 the monstrous way she died.
 But woe on the survivor, too—
 his suffering begins to flower.

ORESTES

Did she commit the crime or not? Come here.
 This clothing is my witness, dyed with blood.
 It's from Aegisthus' blade. These bloody stains
 with time have blotted out the fine embroidery.
 But I can praise my father. Now at last
 I'm here to mourn him, as I hold this robe,
 the net that brought about my father's death.
 But I lament my act, my suffering.
 I mourn the entire race, for though I've won,
 I can't avoid the guilt which now pollutes me.

1260 [1010]

CHORUS

No mortal goes through life unscathed,
 free from pain until the end.
 One trouble comes today,
 yet another comes tomorrow.

1270

[1020]

ORESTES [*starting to break down*]

But still, you need to understand . . .
 I don't know how this will end . . . I feel like
 some chariot racer lashing on my team,
 but we're way off track . . . My mind is racing . . .
 it's lost control. Something's overpowering me . . .
 carrying me off . . . Deep in my heart, fear
 prepares its furious song and dance.
 So while I still have my wits about me,
 to all my friends I publicly proclaim

1280

I killed my mother not without just cause.
 She was guilty of my father's murder,
 a woman gods despised. What drove me on?
 I cite as my chief cause the Delphic prophet, [1030]
 Apollo's priest, who said this to me,
 "If you carry out this act, you'll go free—
 no charge of evil. But if you refuse . . ."
 I won't describe the punishment— 1290
 no arrow fired from a bow could reach
 the top of so much pain.

[Pylades hands Orestes an olive branch, the mark of a suppliant to Apollo's oracle at Delphi.]

Look at me now—
 armed with this branch and wreath, I go
 a suppliant to earth's central navel stone,
 Apollo's realm, to that sacred flame
 which, people say, never dies away,
 an exile who murdered his own blood.
 Apollo's prophet gave me his orders—
 I'm to go to his shrine, no other place.
 As to how I did this brutal act, 1300
 I call all men of Argos—be my witnesses [1040]
 to Menelaus when he comes back home.
 Remember me in years to come. Now I go,
 wandering in exile from my country.
 Whether I live or die, I leave with you
 your memory of me.

CHORUS LEADER

But you've done great things.
 Why depress your spirit with such talk,
 ominous predictions, evil omens?
 You've freed the city, all of Argos,
 hacking off the heads of those two serpents, 1310
 a healing blow.

[Orestes is suddenly overpowered with fear by a vision of his mother's Furies coming after him.]

ORESTES

No . . . They're here . . .
 Look, you women . . . over there . . .
 like Gorgons draped in black . . . their heads

hundreds of writhing snakes . . .
I can't stand it here . . .

[1050]

CHORUS LEADER

What's wrong? What are you looking at?
Of all men you have a father's strongest love,
so stay calm. Don't give in to fear

ORESTES

It's no imagined horror, no!
It's real. Out there my mother's blood hounds wait.
They want revenge.

CHORUS LEADER

Your hands are still bloodstained—
that's made your mind disordered.

ORESTES

Lord Apollo!
They come at me! Hordes of them! Their eyes
drip blood . . . it's horrible!

1320

CHORUS LEADER

There's just one cure—
Apollo's touch will cleanse you, set you free
of these hallucinations.

[1060]

ORESTES

You don't see them. I do.
They're coming for me. I have to leave . . .

[Orestes runs off. Pylades follows him.]

CHORUS LEADER

Good fortune go with you. And may god
watch over you, protect you with his favours.

CHORUS

The third storm has broken on the palace,
then run its course across the royal clan.
First, came the torments of those children

1330

slaughtered for Thyestes' food.¹³ Next came
the suffering of a man, our warrior lord,
Achaëa's king. And now the third—
do I call him our saviour or our doom?
When will all this cease? When will murder,
its fury spent, rest at last in sleep?

[1070]

[The Chorus slowly leaves the scene.]

¹³Thyestes, father of Aegisthus, was a brother of Atreus and thus uncle of Agamemnon. Atreus had killed Thyestes's two sons and served them to him at what was supposed to be a feast of reconciliation. Aegisthus's murder of Agamemnon is his revenge for those killings.